Score-Then-Select Sparse Attention in Multi-Agent Communication: Operation-Count Limits and Measured Latency

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Abstract

Sparse attention in multi-agent communication is commonly motivated by the operations it removes. We study when that saving becomes elapsed time, with a cost model that charges each peer-selection rule for what it costs to run. Rules that select peers by their attention scores must compute every score first, so they can remove at most half of the arithmetic of an attention forward pass at any sparsity. Rules that select before scoring escape this bound by an amount set by the selector's own cost, which separates selectors capped by a constant from those that are not. A byte count predicts when compacting the retained peers adds more memory traffic than it removes. Measurements of verified-equivalent implementations on one GPU architecture support each prediction. Composed from library operators, score-then-select attention is slower than dense attention at every configuration we measure. Fused kernels are faster only when one peer is retained, at narrow heads and without tensor cores; with TF32 or bf16 the advantage disappears beyond two hundred agents, and from four retained peers upward they are 1.3 to 28 times slower. Selecting before scoring with a sub-quadratic selector and a fused kernel makes the attention stage up to sixteen times faster than dense. The practical implication is to charge the selector and to measure the kernel that runs.

1 Introduction

Cooperative multi-agent systems increasingly exchange learned messages, and attention is the usual mechanism for deciding whose message matters (Das et al., 2019; Jiang & Lu, 2018; Jiang et al., 2020). Attention over N agents is pairwise, so its cost grows quadratically, and a large part of the literature on learned communication restricts who attends to whom. The restriction is commonly justified by an operation count: if each agent aggregates messages from k peers instead of $N-1$, the aggregation shrinks by a factor of about N/k.

This paper asks when that saving becomes elapsed time. The question has two parts that an operation count conflates. The first is *which operations can be removed at all.* Selecting peers by their attention scores requires the scores, so by the time the selection is made every pairwise interaction has been evaluated; only the aggregation can shrink. The second is *whether the removed operations were what the time was spent on.* At the agent counts and head widths multi-agent communication uses, attention is memory-bound, so an implementation that removes arithmetic while adding data movement can become slower. We study both parts for centralised inference on a single device, the setting in which most of this literature is trained and evaluated, and not for bandwidth-constrained distributed deployment, where reducing transmitted messages is itself the objective.

Approach. We develop a cost model that charges a peer-selection rule for what it costs to run, and test each of its predictions against measurements of implementations that compute the same function. The model has three parts. For *score-then-select* rules, which form every score before keeping the k largest, the removable forward-pass arithmetic is at most half, whatever the sparsity. For rules that fix the retained

set before any score exists, the achievable saving is determined by the selector's own cost, which separates mechanisms that are bounded by a constant from those that are not. And a byte-count criterion, $kd \leq N$, predicts when compacting the retained peers is traffic-neutral. We then measure six implementations of top-k attention, verified equivalent at every reported configuration, against a dense baseline that is the best of a vendor library and a dense kernel we wrote and tuned over the same parameter space as the sparse kernels, and repeat the comparison in three numerical formats with FlexAttention added.

Findings. Composed from general-purpose tensor operations, top-k attention is slower than dense attention at every agent count and sparsity we measure, by up to a factor of thirty-seven, because of memory traffic. A fused kernel removes most of that overhead. It is faster than the best dense implementation only when one peer is retained (two at a single configuration), only at head widths 16 and 32, and only without tensor cores: in TF32 and bf16 dense attention gains three to eight times, and the advantage is gone from 384 agents upward. From four retained peers upward the fused kernel is slower in every configuration we could compare, because ranking candidates costs more than aggregating over survivors saves. Selecting before scoring changes the picture: fused, the attention stage becomes up to sixteen times faster than dense attention, and the selector then decides the outcome. An all-pairs nearest-neighbour selector is capped by a constant and ends far behind dense attention; a grid-based one removes the quadratic growth but not a large constant; and a space-filling-curve selector, cheap in absolute terms, reaches parity with dense attention at five hundred agents on best-case timings.

Contributions.

- A cost model for peer selection in attention-based communication (Section 3). Under a multiply–accumulate count, any score-then-select rule removes at most half of the forward-pass attention arithmetic (Proposition 1); charging a selector for its own cost places existing mechanisms into four classes with different asymptotic savings (Proposition 2, Corollary 1); and a byte criterion predicts when compaction is traffic-neutral.
- A measurement of what is executed (Section 4): masked, gathered and fused implementations of one function, a dense baseline searched over one parameter space under one admissibility filter with the achieved fraction of device throughput reported for both, and a check of whether the conclusions depend on numerical precision.
- A characterisation of when sparse attention is faster in this regime: narrowly for score-then-select (one or two retained peers, narrow heads, no tensor cores), and more broadly for selection before scoring, provided the selector is sub-quadratic and the remaining attention is fused (Sections 4.4–4.6).

We release the kernels, the measurement harness and a script that re-derives every number in the text from the released artifacts. A secondary pre-registered training study (Appendix G) establishes that the communication architecture being sparsified improves return, so that the cost comparisons concern a mechanism that does something; it is not powered to compare sparsification variants, and no claim in the main text rests on it. Section 5 states the measured envelope: one GPU architecture, head widths 16 to 512, and at most 512 agents.

2 Related Work

Communication sparsity in multi-agent reinforcement learning. Learned inter-agent communication has converged on attention for deciding whose message matters: CommNet broadcasts mean-pooled hidden states (Sukhbaatar et al., 2016), TarMAC introduces signature-based targeting (Das et al., 2019), and MAT casts the joint policy as a sequence model (Wen et al., 2022). Because attention over N agents is pairwise, much of this literature restricts who communicates, usually motivated by cost; DGN observes that receiving much information "requires high bandwidth and incurs high computational complexity" (Jiang et al., 2020). Corollary 1 sorts these mechanisms by what their selector costs. DGN's nearest neighbours,

ATOC's communication field and mean-field interaction fix the retained set from structure available before any score exists (Jiang et al., 2020; Jiang & Lu, 2018; Yang et al., 2018); they are free if the neighbourhood arrives with the environment and case (b) if it is recomputed from all pairwise positions each step. IC3Net and SchedNet gate or rank agents by a scalar per agent, a top-k over an $O(N)$ vector rather than an $N \times N$ matrix (Singh et al., 2019; Kim et al., 2019). G2ANet and MAGIC run a pairwise hard-attention or graph-construction network before communication attention (Liu et al., 2020b; Niu et al., 2021), so their selector is of the same order as the scores they avoid. Score-then-select is the limiting case: the adaptive sparse communication graph of Sun et al. (2020) applies a sparsemax generalisation to logits already formed for every pair and motivates it partly by reduced complexity, and handshake mechanisms that match a query against every candidate key before selecting (Liu et al., 2020a) are score-then-select in the same sense. These methods operate with two to roughly thirty agents, DGN reaching the low hundreds. Of the multi-agent papers we relied on that make an efficiency claim, one of five reports a measured time attributable to the mechanism (Appendix H).

Efficient and sparse attention. Efficient-attention methods separate along the same axis. Sparse Transformers, Longformer and BigBird fix the interaction pattern in advance, so the score computation itself is sparse and the selector is essentially free (Child et al., 2019; Beltagy et al., 2020; Zaheer et al., 2020). Reformer and Routing Transformer restrict candidates by hashing and online clustering, which are content-dependent but evaluate scores only for candidate pairs, at a selector cost that must be counted (Kitaev et al., 2020; Roy et al., 2021). Performer keeps every interaction and reorders the algebra (Choromanski et al., 2021). Top-k attention in sequence models is the closest analogue of our mechanism: the Explicit Sparse Transformer keeps the k largest scores per query (Zhao et al., 2019), and Gupta et al. (2021) compute each query's exact top-k over all keys in chunks, with memory efficiency as the stated benefit. Sparsemax and α-entmax obtain exact zeros from the normalisation rather than a hard cutoff (Martins & Astudillo, 2016; Peters et al., 2019); because their zeros arrive after the scores exist, they fall under Proposition 1, which is our inference rather than a claim they make. Sparse mixture-of-experts routing is also score-then-select (Shazeer et al., 2017; Fedus et al., 2022), but the router is small relative to the expert computation it gates, so the analogue of our score term is minor and the saving is real. Whether score-then-select pays therefore depends on the ratio between the cost of scoring every candidate and the cost of the work skipped, which is one in single-head attention.

Hardware-aware execution. That operation counts do not determine runtime is established in general terms (Dehghani et al., 2022), and transformer workloads are known to be dominated by data movement rather than arithmetic (Ivanov et al., 2021); the roofline model formalises when arithmetic ceases to govern runtime (Williams et al., 2009). FlashAttention and its successors reduce memory traffic without changing the operation count (Dao et al., 2022; Dao, 2024; Shah et al., 2024; Rabe & Staats, 2021), and FlexAttention compiles attention variants expressed as score modifications and block masks into fused kernels (Dong et al., 2025). Native Sparse Attention and MiniMax Sparse Attention show where sparse attention does pay: blockwise selection amortises the selector over blocks, preserves matrix-multiply shapes inside selected tiles, and operates at 10^4 to 10^6 tokens, where the skipped work is large (Yuan et al., 2025; Lai et al., 2026). Relative to this literature our contribution is specific: a selector-cost accounting that separates mechanisms before measurement, a byte criterion for per-pair compaction, and measurements at tens to hundreds of agents and narrow heads, where neither block amortisation nor large skipped work is available. Our benchmarking follows established practice for reporting performance on shared hardware (Hoefler & Belli, 2015), and our kernels are written in Triton (Tillet et al., 2019). The training study follows Papoudakis et al. (2021) and Agarwal et al. (2021), with environments from PettingZoo/MPE (Terry et al., 2021) and MAPPO (Yu et al., 2022).

3 A Cost Model for Peer Selection

3.1 Setting and implementations

Consider one round of scaled dot-product attention over N agents, per batch element and head, at head width d. Agent i forms a query q_i; every agent contributes a key and a value; self-attention is masked. Write



Figure 1: Two implementations of dense attention and three of top-k attention, computing two functions in five ways. All five evaluate every pairwise score, because a score-then-select rule must form the complete score vector before it can rank it. They differ in what reaches memory and in how much arithmetic the aggregation performs; only the gathered and fused top-k variants execute the saving that motivates sparsification. The fused row stands for the kernels that compact the retained set; the threshold kernel of Section 4.4 is fused in the same sense but keeps the dense aggregation.

$s_i = q_i K^\top \in \mathbb{R}^N$ for the score vector and $a_i = \mathrm{softmax}(s_i)$, so that dense attention computes $m_i = a_i V$. A top-k variant keeps the k largest entries of a_i and renormalises over them. We call a rule that forms the complete score vector and then keeps its k largest entries *score-then-select*. Every analytic claim below concerns that class, not content-dependent selection in general, and Section 3.3 draws the boundary.

Attention has two matrix products of equal size: one produces the pairwise scores and the other aggregates the values. Restricting the retained set shrinks the second, because only k value rows are combined, and cannot shrink the first, because the scores are what the selection reads. The same top-k function also admits several implementations (Figure 1), and whether the saving is executed depends on which one runs.

Masked top-k multiplies the dense weights by a $\{0, 1\}$ mask and renormalises. The discarded entries are materialised as zeros and multiplied, so the executed aggregation is that of dense attention.

Gathered top-k takes the top-k of the raw scores, applies a softmax over those k values, gathers the corresponding value rows into a (B, N, k, d) tensor and contracts it. The aggregation genuinely shrinks.

Fused top-k computes the same function in one kernel, holding the score row on chip, selecting within it and accumulating the weighted values without writing a score matrix, an index tensor or a gathered tensor to memory (Section 4.4).

Gathered and masked top-k compute the same function, since softmax is monotone within a row and a softmax over the k retained scores equals the dense softmax restricted to them and renormalised; all implementations we time agree to floating-point tolerance (Appendix F).

3.2 An operation-count ceiling for score-then-select

We count multiply–accumulates (MACs) of the two attention products and exclude the input and output projections shared by every implementation:

$$C_{\text{dense}} = \underbrace{N^2 d}_{\text{scores}} + \underbrace{N^2 d}_{\text{aggregate}}, \qquad C_{\text{top-}k} = \underbrace{N^2 d}_{\text{all scores}} + \underbrace{Nkd}_{\text{aggregate } k}. \tag{1}$$

Proposition 1 (Score-then-select ceiling)**.** *Let the retained set be fixed by a score-then-select rule, one whose kept indices are determined only after the complete score vector of each query has been formed, and let keys and values have equal width. Then, for the forward pass,*

$$\frac{C_{dense}}{C_{top\text{-}k}} = \frac{2N}{N+k} < 2 \qquad \textit{for all } k \geq 1, \tag{2}$$

with supremum 2 *approached only as* $k/N \to 0$*.*

Why it matters. The saving usually quoted for top-k communication, $1 - k/(N-1)$, describes the aggregation term alone. Read as the saving of the mechanism it overstates the achievable reduction by a factor approaching two, before any question of whether the reduction is realised in time. The bound depends only on *when* the retained set is fixed: a rule that must read every score pays for every score.

The proof, the treatment of the masked diagonal and six assumptions (single round, full-score selection, per head, projections excluded, selection cost excluded, equal key and value widths) are in Appendix A; each assumption other than full-score selection either leaves the ratio unchanged or moves it closer to one. The ceiling is a statement about the forward pass. In training, exact selection is piecewise constant in the scores, so the backward products run over the retained pairs only and the analogous bound is $6N/(N+5k) < 6$ (Appendix A). Every timing claim in this paper concerns the forward pass unless stated otherwise.

3.3 Selection before scoring

Mechanisms that are content-dependent but do not read the complete score vector lie outside Proposition 1: nearest-neighbour retrieval, clustering, routing, hashing and fixed patterns can identify candidates without forming every score (Kitaev et al., 2020; Roy et al., 2021; Yuan et al., 2025). What they pay instead is the cost of deciding, and we charge it explicitly.

Proposition 2 (Selection before scoring)**.** *Suppose the retained set is determined without forming the complete score vector, at total selector cost* $C_{\text{sel}}(N, k, d)$*, and that scores are then evaluated only for the* Nk *retained pairs. Then*

$$S = \frac{C_{dense}}{C_{\text{pre}}} = \frac{2N^2 d}{2Nkd + C_{\text{sel}}}. \tag{3}$$

(i) If $C_{\text{sel}} = o(Nkd)$*, then* $S/(N/k) \to 1$*; equality with* N/k *holds only for* $C_{\text{sel}} = 0$*. (ii) If* $C_{\text{sel}} = o(N^2 d)$ *and* $k/N \to 0$*, then* S *diverges, though not in general at the rate* N/k*.*

A score-then-select rule is the limiting case. It has formed every score while selecting, so written in this form its selector cost is at least the scores of the discarded pairs, $C_{\text{sel}} \geq N^2 d - Nkd$, and substituting recovers Proposition 1. Read together, the two propositions place every peer-selection mechanism on one axis — the cost of deciding what to keep — and the position on that axis bounds what the mechanism can save.

Corollary 1 (What a selector costs, and what it can buy)**.** *Count* C_{sel} *in MAC-equivalents, one comparison, integer operation or distance term being one unit. Fix* k *and* d *and let* $N \to \infty$*.* (a) Full-score selection, $C_{\text{sel}} \geq N^2 d - Nkd$*:* $S < 2$*.* (b) All-pairs selection in a feature space of dimension p, $C_{\text{sel}} = \gamma N^2 p$*:* $S \to 2d/(\gamma p)$*, a constant.* (c) Sub-quadratic selection, $C_{\text{sel}} = \Theta(N \log N)$*:* $S = \Theta(Nd/\log N)$*, unbounded but a vanishing fraction of* N/k*.* (d) Linear selection, $C_{\text{sel}} = cNkd$ *for a constant* $c > 0$*:* $S \to 2N/((2+c)k)$*; and* $S \sim N/k$ *when* $C_{\text{sel}} = o(Nkd)$*, as for a fixed or precomputed pattern.*

Why it matters. Only a free selector delivers the N/k that operation-count arguments for sparse communication usually invoke, and only full-score selection is bounded by two. The intermediate cases are where multi-agent methods sit, and they differ: a selector that ranks all pairs in a cheap feature space escapes the twofold ceiling and still cannot exceed a constant, while a sub-quadratic one is unbounded. The asymptotic classes do not depend on the unit convention; the constants in the closed forms of Section 4.6 do. Proofs are in Appendix A.

3.4 Why the count need not govern the time

For memory-bound kernels, time tracks bytes moved rather than arithmetic performed (Williams et al., 2009). At the head widths multi-agent communication uses, both paths in this study have an arithmetic intensity below every machine balance we measure on the same device (Appendix F.5), so the relevant accounting is of bytes. Gathering does not remove memory traffic; it relocates it. Instead of multiplying $N-k$ zeros, the gathered path writes and re-reads a compacted (B, N, k, d) tensor and the indices that build it.

Byte criterion. Counting each tensor read or written once, the compacted operand of the gathered aggregation holds kd elements per query and the score row it replaces holds N, so gathering is byte-neutral only when $kd \leq N$. At d=16 and N=512 the criterion admits $k \leq 32$; at d=128 it admits only $k \leq 4$. Unlike the operation count, this criterion depends on d, and it can be checked before any code is written. Section 4 tests the ceiling, the selector classes and the byte criterion against measurements.

4 Experiments

The experiments answer three questions in turn. Does score-then-select reduce the computation that is executed (Section 4.2)? Does the reduced computation become reduced latency (Section 4.3)? And under what conditions can sparse attention be faster than dense attention (Sections 4.4–4.6)?

4.1 Setup

We time the attention core — from queries, keys and values to the message tensor — because the input and output projections are shared by every implementation and dilute the quantity in question. Unless stated otherwise the configuration is fp32, head width d=16, batch 256, on one NVIDIA Blackwell GPU (sm_120) under PyTorch 2.11, CUDA 12.8 and Triton 3.6. The dense baseline is the fastest of PyTorch's fused scaled-dot-product path and a streaming dense kernel we wrote in Triton and tuned over the same parameter space and admissibility filter as our sparse kernels; the precision study adds FlexAttention (Dong et al., 2025). Every ratio in this paper is against that best dense implementation.

Timing uses on-device CUDA events with explicit synchronisation. The device was shared with other tenants and clocks could not be locked, so implementations are timed *interleaved*, repetition by repetition, within one sweep per agent count; interference then lands on all of them together and their ratios stay paired. The primary statistic is the minimum over samples, an estimate of the uncontended cost; the whole block is repeated three times and we report where the paired median changes a conclusion. Recomputing every comparison from paired medians changes which implementation is faster at one of 24 configurations in the main sweep, and reverses the end-to-end pre-score result of Section 4.6 in one of its two sweeps; both are stated where they occur. Agent counts below 192 are launch-bound on this device and are shown for continuity only. Every implementation is checked against a reference at every configuration whose latency is reported, and all agree to fp32 rounding except at exact ties at the k-th score (Appendix F). Appendix B.1 gives the full protocol and Appendix C the errors it guards against.

4.2 Q1: Is the reduction executed?

Only in some implementations, and the count cannot tell which. PyTorch's FLOP counter, attached to the running program, confirms that the gathered implementation executes the reduction Proposition 1 permits.

Table 1: Forward latency (ms, minimum over interleaved samples) of one function computed six ways, at a quarter of peers retained. The composed sparse path is slower than every dense implementation at every agent count, and the gap widens with N; the fused kernels change the picture only at small k (Section 4.4). Rows below N=192 are launch-bound and carry no claim (Appendix E.3).

		dense				**top-k**			
N	k	unfused	fused (library)	ours	ours (tuned)	gathered (composed)	fused gather	fused mask	best sparse ÷ best dense
12	2	0.012	0.013	0.004	0.004	0.022	0.004	0.006	0.99
24	4	0.015	0.011	0.004	0.004	0.028	0.006	0.016	1.37
48	8	0.020	0.015	0.008	0.008	0.048	0.012	0.024	1.54
96	16	0.045	0.033	0.018	0.014	0.120	0.049	0.039	2.80
192	32	0.136	0.072	0.036	0.034	0.424	0.387	2.305	11.29
384	64	1.082	0.220	0.119	0.108	2.405	2.750	2.025	18.70
512	128	1.899	0.349	0.188	0.172	6.435	7.214	2.662	15.44

The masked implementation multiplies the discarded entries as zeros and so executes dense arithmetic plus selection, while a count based on the retained fraction credits it with a 75% saving at N=512, k=127.

4.3 Q2: Does the reduction become time?

Not in this regime. Composed from general-purpose operators, the gathered path executes less arithmetic than dense attention and is slower than every dense implementation at every agent count we measure, by up to a factor of thirty-seven at 512 agents and a quarter of peers retained (Table 1).

The byte criterion of Section 3.4 accounts for this. Gathering adds a compacted (B, N, k, d) tensor and its indices and reads both back; at d=16 and N=512 it is byte-neutral only for $k \leq 32$, and the quarter-of-peers operating point is four times past that bound. Timed in isolation, the sparse contraction and the dense multiply it replaces both run near the bandwidth the device attains on a large copy, so neither is on a worse hardware path; the sparse one is slower because it moves about four times the bytes. The largest single stage of the composed path is selection, which runs at under a tenth of attainable bandwidth (Appendix B.4). The same criterion explains the head-width dependence reported below: at d=128 it admits only $k \leq 4$ at 512 agents.

The ordering survives the backward pass with a narrower margin — at 512 agents the gathered path is 18.4 times the fused dense path on the forward pass and 6.2 times on forward and backward, since selection has almost no adjoint — and in a complete MAPPO iteration at six to twenty-four agents the environment takes 78 to 96% of the time and all implementations are within 2% of one another (Appendix B.5).

4.4 Q3a: When a fused score-then-select kernel is faster

The composed path spends most of its time moving intermediates that a fused kernel need not create. We wrote fused kernels that hold the score row on chip and never write a score matrix, an index tensor or a gathered value tensor to memory. At 512 agents retaining a single peer the composed sparse path costs 4.62 ms and the fused one 0.139 ms, a factor of 33 attributable to the implementation and not to the algorithm, and the fused path is then faster than the best dense implementation (Figure 2).

Matched authorship is a weaker condition than matched efficiency, so we report the fraction of the device's matrix-multiply rate each kernel reaches beside its latency (Table 2). At head widths 16 and 32 the fused sparse kernel is the *less* efficient of the two at every agent count — 21 to 33% of the device's rate against 30 to 47% for dense — and it is faster at one retained peer only because it performs about half the arithmetic. The search is not equal: above 192 agents the filter admits three sparse configurations against 28 to 106 dense ones, so the sparse figures are lower bounds, the negative entries at head width 64 and above are weakly supported, and the positive entry is conservative.

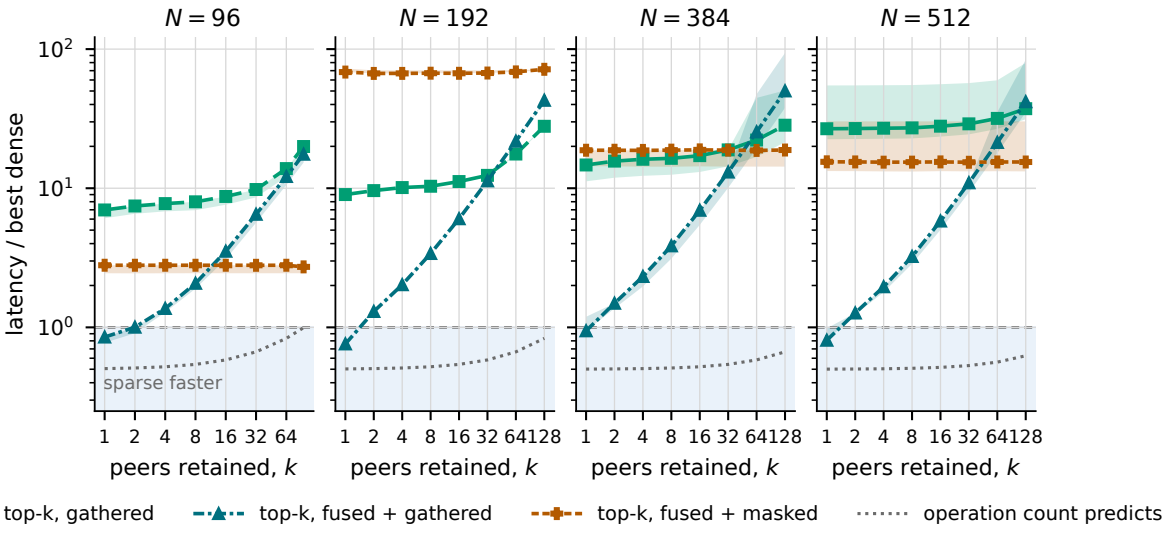


Figure 2: Latency divided by the fastest dense implementation, against the number of peers retained. The dotted line is what an operation count predicts for the gathered path, $(N + k)/2N$, which lies below parity everywhere and so predicts a saving at every sparsity. Shading marks the region in which sparsity is actually faster; only the fused gathered kernel enters it, and only at the smallest k. Lines are ratios of minima; bands span the paired ratios of the three runs' medians, and so show how far each point moves between runs and under a change of estimator. The N=96 panel is launch-bound and carries no claim.

Table 2: Both kernels searched over one parameter space — query tile, key tile or head chunk, warp count and pipeline depth — under one shared-memory admissibility filter, with the better of the search and the vendor library taken as the dense baseline. The *cfgs* columns are how many configurations each search admitted; the sparse kernel must hold an N-wide score tile, so above 192 agents only three fit. Efficiency is executed arithmetic over elapsed time, against the matrix-multiply rate the device attains in the same process.

		best dense				**best sparse**					
d	N	from	cfgs	ms	% peak	k	cfgs	ms	% peak	ratio	k that pays
16	192	triton	106	0.0347	30	1	12	0.0249	21	0.72	≤ 1
16	384	triton	106	0.1082	38	1	3	0.0941	22	0.87	≤ 1
16	512	triton	106	0.1681	44	1	3	0.1293	29	0.77	≤ 1
32	192	triton	94	0.0555	38	1	18	0.0428	24	0.77	≤ 1
32	384	triton	94	0.1923	43	1	3	0.1618	26	0.84	≤ 1
32	512	triton	94	0.3179	47	1	3	0.2231	33	0.70	≤ 2
64	192	sdpa	64	0.0862	48	1	21	0.0962	22	1.12	none
64	384	sdpa	64	0.2720	61	1	3	0.4321	19	1.59	none
64	512	sdpa	64	0.4361	68	1	3	0.5634	26	1.29	none
128	192	sdpa	28	0.1665	50	2	18	0.1724	24	1.04	none
128	384	sdpa	28	0.4688	71	1	3	0.8582	19	1.83	none
128	512	sdpa	28	0.7656	77	1	3	1.1784	25	1.54	none

The advantage is narrow. It appears at one retained peer, and at two only at d=32, N=512; the k=1 case is degenerate as attention, since a softmax over one element is identically one. At four retained peers the fused kernel is 1.3 to 2.1 times slower than dense, and at a quarter of peers more than an order of magnitude slower. The cause is selection. Repeated argmax costs k dependent row-wide reductions; bisection on the score's bit pattern is flat in k but aggregates densely; and a single sort is flat and sparse but costs five to

Table 3: The fused crossover in three numerical formats. Each hand-written kernel is searched separately in each format; the best dense implementation is the fastest of the vendor library, FlexAttention (*flex*) and our tuned kernel (*ours*). Ratios are of minima, with the paired-median ratio at one retained peer beside it. A dash marks a configuration in which TF32 rounding changed the retained peer in more than 0.1% of query rows. The last column is top-k through FlexAttention with a block mask built from the retained set.

			best dense		**fused top-k ÷ best dense**				**Flex**
d	N	format	from	ms	k=1	k=1 (med.)	k=2	k=4	k=1
16	192	fp32	ours	0.0325	0.76	0.73	1.25	2.07	10.16
		tf32	ours	0.0119	1.01	0.89	1.34	—	28.84
		bf16	ours	0.0083	0.95	0.84	1.69	2.23	43.63
16	384	fp32	ours	0.1060	0.91	0.94	1.50	2.01	16.51
		tf32	flex	0.0284	1.07	1.06	—	—	58.07
		bf16	flex	0.0163	1.28	1.26	2.63	4.13	102.00
16	512	fp32	ours	0.1674	0.77	0.82	1.24	1.67	33.40
		tf32	flex	0.0445	1.09	1.04	—	—	115.54
		bf16	flex	0.0242	1.11	0.99	2.35	3.62	218.40
32	192	fp32	ours	0.0549	0.70	0.75	1.05	1.48	7.71
		tf32	ours	0.0168	0.83	0.87	1.11	—	21.99
		bf16	flex	0.0103	0.98	0.91	1.56	2.14	36.60
32	384	fp32	ours	0.1884	0.82	0.85	1.13	1.66	9.96
		tf32	flex	0.0507	1.29	1.38	1.69	—	33.54
		bf16	flex	0.0250	1.38	1.36	2.11	3.03	67.97
32	512	fp32	ours	0.3174	0.67	0.71	0.92	1.28	17.83
		tf32	flex	0.0797	1.25	1.28	—	—	84.33
		bf16	flex	0.0393	1.20	1.22	1.81	2.61	147.88

sixteen times dense attention (Appendix B.2). None of the three changes the outcome. What is fundamental to exact score-then-select is that all N scores are *computed*; that our kernels also hold them *resident* is a property of our implementations, and a streaming exact top-k might do better.

4.5 Q3b: Does the crossover depend on precision?

The single-peer advantage above is measured in fp32 with IEEE products, which keeps every kernel off the tensor cores so that it reproduces the reference summation order. That is the format in which dense attention is least advantaged. We repeated the comparison in TF32 and bf16, searching both kernels again in each format under the same admissibility filter, and added FlexAttention (Dong et al., 2025) twice: as a dense baseline, and as PyTorch's route to data-dependent sparsity, with the top-k retained set expressed as a block mask (Table 3).

Tensor cores help dense attention far more than they help the fused top-k kernel. The best dense implementation becomes 2.7 to 4.0 times faster in TF32 than in fp32, and 3.9 to 8.1 times faster in bf16. The fused kernel at one retained peer, faster than dense at every agent count in fp32 (0.67 to 0.91), is slower from 384 agents upward in both reduced formats (1.07 to 1.38) and at most marginally faster at 192 agents (0.83 to 1.01). This separates the two readings that the fp32 data could not: at a fixed head width, raising the efficiency of dense attention removes the crossover, so it depends on how close dense attention runs to

Table 4: Selecting before scoring, at 4 retained peers: selector latency (ms) and end-to-end latency (selector plus fused attention) divided by the best dense implementation of the same interleaved sweep. The grid selector's recall is the fraction of exact nearest neighbours it retains. The Z-order path is shown on minima and on paired medians, and through FlexAttention with the window expressed as a band mask. Rows below N=192 are launch-bound.

	all-pairs kNN		**grid kNN**			**Z-order, fused**		**Z-order**
N	select	total	select	total	recall	min	median	**Flex**
48	0.048	8.12	0.047	8.09	1.0000	15.73	11.04	17.63
96	0.099	7.72	0.098	7.54	1.0000	8.62	7.69	14.97
192	0.317	10.08	0.506	16.09	1.0000	3.79	3.58	4.63
384	1.813	16.93	1.185	11.17	1.0000	1.26	1.34	2.25
512	5.692	37.48	1.669	9.85	0.9999	0.86	0.92	1.61

the machine rather than on the head width as such. TF32 also changes the function computed. Rounding the products reorders near-tied scores, so every top-k implementation — fused, composed or FlexAttention — retains a different peer from a float64 reference in up to 0.7% of query rows, rising with k; we exclude configurations above 0.1%, which removes most TF32 entries beyond one retained peer, and since cost rises with k those entries could only be slower.

FlexAttention is the fastest dense implementation in nine of the twelve reduced-precision configurations, which supports the choice of baseline. As a route to top-k sparsity it is 8 to 218 times slower than dense attention: the retained set must first be ranked from a full score matrix and converted into a block mask on every call, and at 128-wide blocks every block of the mask contains a retained pair, so the kernel then computes densely.

4.6 Q3c: Selecting before scoring

We test Proposition 2 with three selectors, each used by existing multi-agent mechanisms and each in a different class of Corollary 1. *All-pairs nearest neighbours* ranks the distances between two-dimensional positions, as a neighbourhood rule recomputed each step does (Jiang et al., 2020; Jiang & Lu, 2018); it is case (b), and its count ratio rises towards d and no further. *Grid nearest neighbours* buckets agents in a uniform grid and ranks only the candidates in the surrounding 3×3 cells; its cost is $\Theta(Nk)$ at bounded density, case (d), and it retains the exact nearest neighbours in at least 99.93% of cases. *Z-order* orders agents along a Morton curve and keeps the k adjacent in that order; its sort is $O(N \log N)$, case (c). Closed forms are in Appendix A.4. Attention then runs over the retained pairs only, composed from library operators or as a fused kernel that reads one key and one value row per retained peer; the Z-order window, a band in curve order, also runs through FlexAttention. The selectors attend to different peers than top-k, so the comparison is of cost, not quality.

The attention stage. Once the retained set is known, the fused attention over it is what the accounting predicts: at two retained peers it costs 0.06 times dense attention at 512 agents, more than sixteen times faster, and its advantage grows with the agent count because the score term now shrinks with the aggregation (Figure 3). Composed from library operators the same stage is slower than dense attention at every agent count and sparsity measured, and fusing it is worth a factor of 4 to 17 (Appendix B.7). No score-then-select implementation in this paper comes close, because none can remove the score term.

End to end, the selector decides. The three selectors separate as Corollary 1 predicts, and by more than their operation counts suggest (Table 4). The all-pairs selector's cost grows quadratically, from 0.32 to 5.69 ms between 192 and 512 agents at four retained peers, and its path ends 37 times slower than dense attention; the cap binds far below its analytic value because the selector's cost is traffic rather than arithmetic. The grid selector removes the quadratic growth — its cost rises from 0.51 to 1.67 ms over the same range — but its constant — gathering and ranking about a hundred candidates per agent at four retained peers — keeps the path 10 times slower than dense at 512 agents, and at sixteen retained peers it

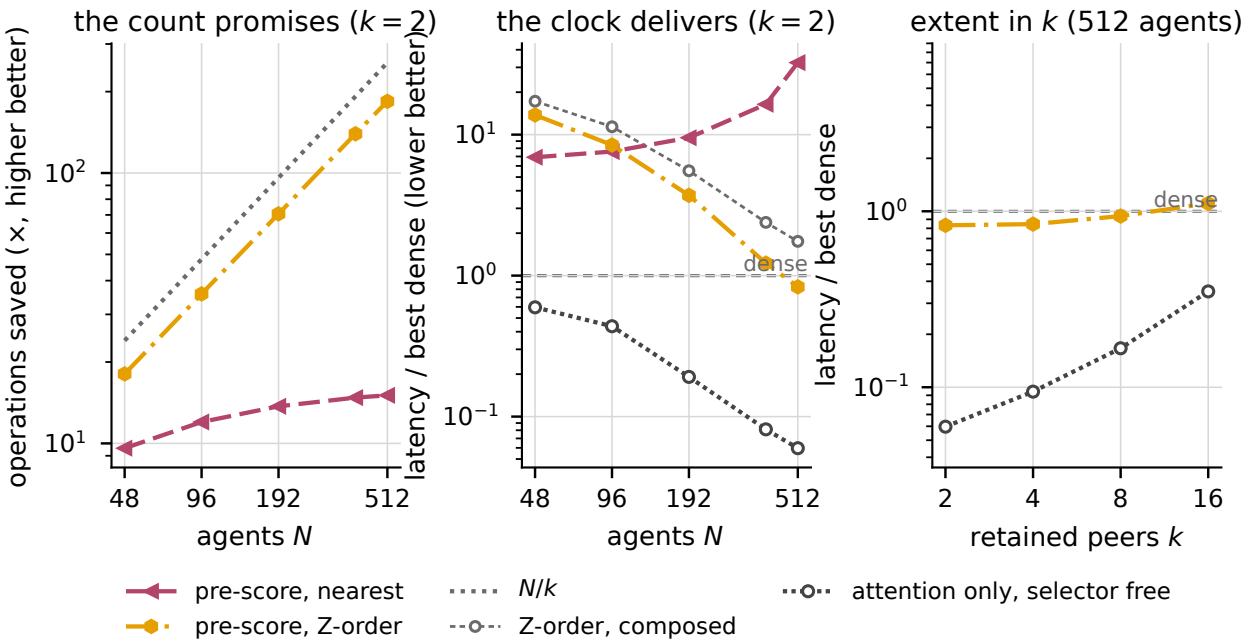


Figure 3: First pre-score sweep. **Left:** the operation-count saving the accounting of Section 3.3 promises. The dotted line is N/k, the figure a free selector would reach; the sub-quadratic selector stays below it by a factor that widens with N, and the all-pairs selector is capped by a constant (Corollary 1). **Middle:** what the same configurations cost. Fused, the attention over pre-chosen peers is more than an order of magnitude faster than dense attention at the largest agent count, and the total is then governed by the selector, which is where the two selectors diverge. **Right:** how far the end-to-end crossing extends. It holds at two and four retained peers, is level with dense at eight and gone by sixteen.

is slower than the all-pairs selector at 384 and 512 agents. The Z-order selector's cost is nearly flat, 0.10 to 0.14 ms, so its share falls as attention grows more expensive: the path costs 0.86 times dense at 512 agents and four retained peers, reproducing the first sweep's 0.85. Through FlexAttention the same window costs 1.6 times dense at 512 agents: faster than composing it from library operators, slower than the fused kernel, since at this size the band still touches several of FlexAttention's 128-wide blocks per row.

The end-to-end crossing is a best-case result. It holds on minima in both sweeps, and under the paired median in the second sweep (0.92) but not in the first, where the median costs 2.06 times dense, because a multi-launch path has a heavier tail on a contended device than a single dense kernel (Appendix B.7). It appears only at the largest agent count we measure; at 48 agents the Z-order path is 16 times slower than dense. The subsection therefore identifies conditions — a selector cheap in absolute terms, not only asymptotically, and a fused attention stage behind it — rather than recommending this implementation.

5 Discussion and Limitations

Measurement error. Seven errors produced plausible but spurious results during this study before they were caught, among them a host transfer inside the timed region, sequential timing on a shared device, a masked implementation benchmarked as sparse, and a hand-written sparse kernel compared with a vendor dense kernel tuned for another regime. Appendix C lists each with its symptom and the practice that corrected it.

Limitations. Every cost result concerns centralised inference on a single device; the paper makes no claim about bandwidth-constrained distributed deployment, where reducing transmitted messages is itself the objective and top-k selection may well be the right design. The analysis is single-round and single-head.

The operation-count ratio is invariant to rounds and heads, but the timing result is not guaranteed to be: H heads of width d/H change the per-head width, which is the axis along which our timing result changes sign.

The measured envelope is one GPU architecture (NVIDIA Blackwell, sm_120), one x86_64 CPU, PyTorch 2.11 with CUDA 12.8 and Triton 3.6, head widths 16 to 512, $N \leq 512$, batch 32 to 1024, and fp32, TF32 and bf16. We could not replicate on a second GPU generation, because no other was available to us. Both cards were shared with other tenants throughout, and clocks could not be locked; every claim is therefore a ratio between implementations timed in the same interleaved sweep, and no claim is read off an agent count below 192, where a fixed per-call cost is a large share of the measurement.

Our kernels are not optimal. The sparse kernels hold the whole score row of a query on chip, which caps them at $N \leq 1024$ and admits only three tilings above 192 agents against 28 to 106 for the dense kernel; a streaming exact top-k that keeps a running candidate set would not have that constraint, and we did not write one. The sparse efficiency figures are therefore lower bounds, and the negative results at wide heads are weakly supported. The fused crossover at one retained peer is provisional in the other direction, and Section 4.5 shows how: a dense kernel that uses the tensor cores removes it from 384 agents upward. The pre-score selectors attend to a different peer set than top-k does, so their comparison is of cost and not of quality; their selectors are composed from library operators, so the selector costs we report are upper bounds; and their envelope is one head width, one batch and fp32. Finally, the learning study (Appendix D) has five seeds per variant; it shows that the communication architecture improves return and cannot resolve the effect of any sparsification choice.

6 Conclusion

We characterised when sparse attention in multi-agent communication turns an operation-count saving into a saving in time. For score-then-select rules the answer is bounded before any measurement: because the selection reads every score, at most half of the forward-pass arithmetic is removable, and charging each selection rule for its own cost places every restriction mechanism on a single axis, from full-score selection, bounded by two, to free selection, which attains N/k. The measurements show that the bounded saving is optimistic in this regime. Masked implementations execute none of it; gathered implementations execute it and are slower, because compaction adds more traffic than it removes whenever $kd > N$. Fused kernels remove most of that overhead and are faster than the best dense implementation available to us only at one retained peer (two at a single configuration), at head widths 16 and 32 and without tensor cores; in TF32 and bf16, where dense attention gains three to eight times, the advantage disappears from 384 agents upward, and from four retained peers upward the fused kernels are 1.3 to 28 times slower in fp32.

Selecting before scoring is where the saving becomes real, and the cost model says in advance which selectors can deliver it. Once the attention over pre-selected peers is fused it runs up to sixteen times faster than dense attention; an all-pairs selector then dominates the cost and loses, while a sub-quadratic selector reaches parity with dense attention at five hundred agents on best-case timings. For designers, the practical guidance is to charge the selector, to check $kd \leq N$ before compacting, and to measure the kernel that actually runs.

Broader Impact Statement

This work is a measurement and correction study of a computational-efficiency claim. It introduces no new capability and no new data. Its intended effect is to reduce wasted compute in the design of multi-agent communication architectures by discouraging optimisation against an operation count that does not predict runtime.

Reproducibility Statement

The kernels, measurement harness, analysis scripts and every measurement artifact are provided as anonymised supplementary material and will be released publicly with the camera-ready version. A single script regenerates every table and figure from the artifacts, and a second re-derives every number quoted

in the text and fails on any disagreement. The environment, commands and measurement parameters are listed in Appendix I.

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A Proofs and assumptions

A.1 Proposition 1

Proof. From (1), $C_{\text{top-}k} = N^2d + Nkd > N^2d = \frac{1}{2}C_{\text{dense}}$ for every $k \geq 1$, since $Nkd > 0$, so the ratio $2N/(N+k)$ is below 2. It is decreasing in k, hence largest at $k = 1$, and approaches 2 from below as $k/N \to 0$. □

We use N^2d rather than $N(N-1)d$ because it is the count the implementations execute: self-masking writes $-\infty$ into the diagonal of a full $N \times N$ score matrix and does not skip work. Counting the diagonal exactly gives $2(N-1)/\big((N-1)+k\big)$, which is strictly smaller for every $1 \leq k \leq N-1$, so the proposition is a valid upper bound under either convention.

Six assumptions support the statement, of which only the second is essential. **(A1) Single round**: with R rounds both terms scale by R and the ratio is unchanged. **(A2) Full-score selection**: the retained set is determined only after the complete candidate score vector has been computed, so all N scores must be formed. **(A3) Per head**: with H heads of width d/H both terms scale identically. **(A4) Projections excluded**: including the shared qkv and output projections moves the ratio strictly closer to 1, so the bound remains valid. **(A5) Selection cost excluded**: counting the top-k operation itself can only decrease the ratio, and Appendix B.4 shows the term is large in practice. **(A6) Equal key and value widths**: with key width d_k and value width d_v the two products cost N^2d_k and N^2d_v, and the ceiling is $1 + d_v/d_k$, which is 2 in the equal-width attention used throughout.

A2 concerns *when* the retained set is fixed, not whether the rule depends on the data. Routing Transformer's online k-means routing (Roy et al., 2021) and Reformer's locality-sensitive hash (Kitaev et al., 2020) are content-dependent in every ordinary sense and still evaluate scores only for candidate pairs; a hierarchical rule that ranks compressed blocks and then scores only the selected ones (Yuan et al., 2025) is likewise outside A2. A2 also does not require the scores to be held at once: a streaming selector that keeps a running candidate set computes all N scores without storing them, and remains inside the class.

A.2 The training-time analogue

Exact selection is piecewise constant in the scores, so gradients reach only the retained entries. Of the four products in dense attention's backward pass — the gradients with respect to values, weights, queries and keys, each N^2d — a gathered top-k backward executes each over the Nk retained pairs alone, given the indices recorded in the forward pass. Counting both passes, without recomputation,

$$\frac{C^{\text{f+b}}_{\text{dense}}}{C^{\text{f+b}}_{\text{top-}k}} = \frac{6N^2d}{N^2d + 5Nkd} = \frac{6N}{N+5k} < 6, \tag{4}$$

so in training at most five sixths of attention's arithmetic is removable, against half in inference. A dense implementation that recomputes the scores in its backward pass, as FlashAttention does, adds N^2d to the dense count and raises the bound to 7. The asymmetry is visible in the measurements of Appendix B.5, where the gathered path's backward is cheap relative to its forward.

A.3 Proposition 2 and Corollary 1

Proof of Proposition 2. Both statements read off the displayed ratio. For (i), $2Nkd + C_{\text{sel}} = 2Nkd\,(1+o(1))$, so $S = (N/k)\,(1+o(1))^{-1}$, whose quotient with N/k tends to 1; substituting $C_{\text{sel}} = 0$ gives $2N^2d/2Nkd = N/k$ exactly, and any $C_{\text{sel}} > 0$ strictly enlarges the denominator. For (ii), if $k/N \to 0$ then $2Nkd = o(N^2d)$, so the whole denominator is $o(N^2d)$ and the ratio diverges. □

For a score-then-select rule the displayed form charges the Nk retained scores inside $2Nkd$ although the rule has already formed them while selecting, so its selector cost in this form is at least the scores of the discarded pairs, $C_{\text{sel}} \geq N^2d - Nkd$. That is a lower bound and not an estimate: the ranking itself is uncounted, and

counting it enlarges C_{sel} and shrinks the ratio further. Substituting the bound gives $2N^2d/(N^2d + Nkd)$, which is Proposition 1.

Proof of Corollary 1. Each case substitutes its C_{sel} into the denominator of S. Case (a) is Proposition 1. In (b) the $\gamma N^2 p$ term dominates $2Nkd$ at fixed k and d, giving $S \to 2N^2d/(\gamma N^2 p)$. In (c) the $\Theta(N \log N)$ term likewise dominates $2Nkd$, giving $S = \Theta(N^2d/(N \log N))$, and $S/(N/k) = \Theta(kd/\log N) \to 0$; the statement needs $d = O(1)$, since with $d = \Theta(\log N)$ the penalty disappears. In (d), $S = 2N^2d/((2 + c)Nkd) = 2N/((2+c)k)$ exactly, which is $\Theta(N/k)$ but not asymptotic to it; with $C_{\text{sel}} = o(Nkd)$ it is Proposition 2(i). □

The selector-cost term is material, not decorative. A fixed topology or a precomputed spatial prior really is free at inference and lands in case (d), which is why Longformer and BigBird obtain asymptotic savings where score-then-select top-k cannot (Beltagy et al., 2020; Zaheer et al., 2020): their patterns are fixed before any score is formed, so nothing is spent deciding. A hash must be evaluated and its buckets assembled (Kitaev et al., 2020), and a routing rule must maintain and query its clusters (Roy et al., 2021), so their C_{sel} has to be counted, not assumed away. Between the two sits a family of multi-agent methods whose selector is itself pairwise — a learned hard-attention or scheduling network evaluated over all N^2 pairs before communication attention runs (Liu et al., 2020b; Niu et al., 2021) — and for these C_{sel} is of the same order as the score matrix they avoid, so they inherit a ceiling of the same kind instead of escaping it.

A.4 Closed forms for the measured selectors

The three selectors of Section 4.6, charged under the unit convention of Corollary 1, have closed-form ratios. The all-pairs nearest-neighbour selector charges three operations for each two-dimensional distance and one comparison per candidate, $4N^2$ operations or $2N^2$ MAC-equivalents per batch element, giving $Nd/(kd+N)$; the ranking is charged one comparison per candidate, a lower bound for any selection algorithm, so the formula overstates that selector's ratio. The Z-order selector quantises, interleaves ten bit-pairs and sorts, $N(15 + \lfloor \log_2 N \rfloor + 1)$ MAC-equivalents, giving $4Nd/(4kd + 32 + 2\lfloor \log_2 N \rfloor)$. At 512 agents and four retained peers the first has reached 14.2 against its ceiling of $d = 16$, while the second is at 107 — unbounded in principle, and already only 84% of the $N/k = 128$ that the naive count promises. The grid selector charges one sort to bucket agents and, per agent, a distance and a comparison for each of $9M$ candidates in the surrounding cells, where M is the per-cell capacity; for bounded density $M = \Theta(k)$, so $C_{\text{sel}} = \Theta(Nk)$ and the selector is in case (d) with $c = \Theta(1/d)$.

A.5 Machine balance and arithmetic intensity

We compute arithmetic intensity, floating-point operations per byte of global memory traffic, analytically per stage, counting each tensor read and written once, and compare it against a machine balance measured on the same device: a large matrix multiply gives the achievable arithmetic rate, a large copy gives achievable bandwidth, and their ratio is the ridge point above which a kernel is compute-bound. Counting each tensor once ignores cache residency, so at small N, where the working set fits the GPU's L2, the analytic byte counts overstate traffic; the per-stage accounting of Appendix B.4 flags such stages so the reader need not infer them. The ridge point itself depends on whether the probe's buffer fits the last-level cache, so we measure two of them per device. On the GPU the ridge is 23 FLOP/byte cache-resident and 53 from memory; on the host it is 8 and 28. Both paths in this study sit below every one of those figures at every agent count, on both devices, so the memory-bound conclusion does not depend on which ridge is the relevant one. The per-stage table of Appendix B.4 quotes a third figure, 39, because its probe runs in the same process as the stage timings it scales and measures the arithmetic rate at 57.8 rather than 76.7 TFLOP/s on the same card; every stage sits below that ridge as well. Appendix F.5 gives the probe.

B Measurement details

B.1 Protocol

We time the communication path with the training loop removed. Timing uses on-device CUDA events with an explicit synchronisation on the pinned device, and any diagnostic that transfers a scalar to the host is disabled, because such a transfer synchronises the device inside the timed region. Implementations are timed interleaved repetition by repetition rather than in sequential blocks, so that interference from other tenants lands on all of them at once and their ratios stay paired; the sequential design produced swings above 100% between identical configurations on this shared host. One interleaved group holds every implementation at one agent count, including every retained-peer count of every sparse implementation and the dense implementations they are divided by, so a ratio never spans two groups. The released artifacts record the dense rows with $k = N - 1$, which is a label and not a separate measurement. The primary statistic is the minimum over samples, on the modelling assumption that contention adds time rather than removing it, and the whole timed block is repeated so that the spread of per-run medians is reported and not hidden (Appendix E.2). A minimum estimates an uncontended envelope rather than a service time, so we checked what the choice buys: recomputing every comparison at 192 agents and above from the paired medians of the same samples changes which implementation is faster at one of 24 configurations, 384 agents with a single retained peer, where the ratio moves from 0.94 to 1.14 and the group's recorded inter-run spread is 64%. Neither of the two sweeps that measure the same configuration reproduces the reversal. The pre-score path of Section 4.6 is the one place where the estimator does change a conclusion, and we report it there. GPU clocks could not be locked; the account lacks the privilege. Operation counts are analytic, from a model that follows the convention `torch.utils.flop_counter` uses and that we checked against it on the composed implementations; the hand-written kernels are outside what that counter observes. Every count in this paper is therefore a model, and where a count and a measurement disagree the measurement governs — which is, after all, the paper's subject.

Two decisions about what is compared deserve stating, because both changed our conclusions. First, we time the attention core — from queries, keys and values to the message tensor — rather than the enclosing module, since the shared input and output projections are identical across implementations and dilute the quantity in question. Second, the dense baseline is the better of PyTorch's fused scaled-dot-product path and a dense attention kernel we wrote ourselves in Triton, with the same tiling policy and in the same session as the sparse kernels. At the head widths multi-agent communication uses, the library path is tuned for a different regime, and comparing a hand-written sparse kernel against it credits sparsity with the difference between two authors (Section C).

Every implementation is checked against the reference at every configuration whose latency any artifact reports — 158 of them, 136 with $k < N - 1$ so that selection is exercised. This is not a formality: exact top-k is discontinuous in the scores, so two implementations that accumulate the score product in different orders can rank a near-tied pair differently and then aggregate over different peers. All agree to `fp32` rounding except on four query rows in 1.25 million, where two scores tie exactly at the k-th position and the threshold-selecting kernel keeps one extra peer (Appendix F).

Unless stated otherwise: PyTorch 2.11 with CUDA 12.8 and Triton 3.6, `fp32`, head width d=16, batch 256, and one NVIDIA Blackwell GPU shared with other tenants.

B.2 The fused crossover and three selection strategies

That statement has to be qualified in turn, and the qualification is the more useful result. Matched authorship is a weaker condition than matched efficiency: two kernels written by the same person in the same session can still differ by more than the margin being measured, and only efficiency against the machine identifies the algorithm. We therefore searched the same parameter space for both kernels under the same admissibility filter, took the better of that search and the vendor library as the dense baseline, and report what fraction of the device's own matrix-multiply rate each kernel reaches beside its latency (Table 2).

Table 5: The sparsity at which the best sparse implementation stops being faster than the best dense one, and how far it is from parity at a quarter of the peers. Both ratio columns are a minimum over the composed path and the two fused kernels that rank in registers, so the widest-k column is sometimes the composed path; the sorted kernel of Table 6 is faster than all three from sixteen retained peers upward and is reported there. Restricted to the agent counts at which the kernels are not launch-bound.

	sparsity that pays		**best ratio**		**at the widest k**	
N	k	of peers	ratio	at k	ratio	at k
192	≤ 1	0.5%	0.76	1	27.9	128
384	≤ 1	0.3%	0.94	1	18.8	128
512	≤ 1	0.2%	0.81	1	15.4	128

The search is not equal. All three of our sparse kernels keep the whole score row of a query resident — two rank it in registers and one sorts it in place — so their resident tile grows with the agent count, and above 192 agents the shared-memory filter admits only three configurations against the dense kernel's twenty-eight to a hundred and six. That is a property of the kernels we wrote and not of exact top-k: a selector may compute all N scores without holding them, maintaining a running candidate set as it streams. We did not write one, so the search counts below describe what our implementations admit. We report the counts in the table rather than describing the two searches as equivalent, and the consequence runs in two directions. The sparse kernel's efficiency figure is a lower bound on what a sparse kernel of this shape could reach, so the negative entries at head width 64 and above are weakly supported and we do not build on them. The positive entry is conservative for the same reason: an under-searched sparse kernel that is nonetheless faster is faster.

With that said, two things follow.

The crossover survives tuning, and it is not produced by a sparse kernel that happens to be well written. Across head widths 16 and 32 the sparse kernel is the *less* efficient of the two at every agent count — 21 to 33% of the device's rate against 30 to 47% for dense — and it is faster only because it performs about half the arithmetic.

The crossover is an existence result inside a stated envelope, and the envelope is narrow: one GPU architecture, `fp32`, head widths 16 and 32, agent counts from 192 upward where the sweep reproduces, a single retained peer with one configuration at two, and a dense baseline that reaches under half of the device's arithmetic rate at those head widths. At four retained peers the sparse kernel is already 1.3 to 2.1 times slower, and at a quarter of peers it is more than an order of magnitude slower. The k=1 case is also degenerate as an attention mechanism, because a softmax over one element is identically one and the mechanism reduces to copying the highest-scoring peer's value. What the crossover establishes is that the penalty measured earlier is not irreducible; it is not a recommendation to sparsify.

Why it is confined to narrow heads could not be decided from the fp32 data alone. Dense efficiency and head width move together there — 30% at d=16 rising to 77% at d=128, as the score product becomes a better-shaped matrix multiply — so "the crossover disappears once dense attention is near the machine" and "the crossover disappears above d=32" fit it equally well. The precision study of Section 4.5 separates them: at a fixed head width, a dense kernel that uses the tensor cores removes the crossover from 384 agents upward, which supports the first reading.

Selection is what a successor design has to face, and we tried three ways of doing it. Ranking N candidates to keep k by repeated argmax costs k sequential row-wide reductions, and a reduction of that shape runs at a small fraction of the arithmetic units' throughput because each round depends on the one before it and the hardware has nothing to overlap it with. That is why the argmax kernel's cost grows almost linearly in k while its arithmetic barely does. Bisecting on the score's bit pattern removes the dependence on k, and the only way it can is by expressing the retained set as a zero weight instead of by compaction — so it performs the dense aggregation arithmetic whatever k is.

Table 6: Three ways of reaching the same retained set, at the two agent counts that carry the crossover. Repeated argmax keeps the aggregation sparse and pays linearly in the number retained; bisecting on the score's bit pattern is flat in it and pays the dense aggregation; sorting score–index pairs once is flat and sparse at the same time, and is not competitive with either at the agent counts where a sort no longer fits alongside a useful block of queries.

		k **argmax rounds**		**bisection**		**one sort**	
N	k	ms	÷dense	ms	÷dense	ms	÷dense
192	1	0.026	0.8	2.392	69.4	0.164	4.7
	2	0.045	1.3	2.435	70.7	0.166	4.8
	4	0.069	2.0	2.435	70.7	0.168	4.9
	8	0.116	3.4	2.435	70.7	0.173	5.0
	16	0.206	6.0	2.441	70.8	0.185	5.4
	32	0.385	11.2	2.440	70.8	0.223	6.5
512	1	0.139	0.8	2.970	17.2	2.433	14.1
	2	0.217	1.3	2.716	15.8	2.450	14.2
	4	0.337	2.0	2.764	16.0	2.493	14.5
	8	0.557	3.2	2.912	16.9	2.490	14.5
	16	1.002	5.8	2.911	16.9	2.316	13.4
	32	1.884	10.9	2.920	16.9	2.651	15.4

Whether both can be had at once is the obvious question, and they can (Table 6). Packing each score against its own peer index in one machine word and sorting the row once yields the retained peers already compacted: the aggregation then reads exactly k value rows, while selection costs a single bitonic sort, whose depth grows with the agent count alone and not at all with k. That is visible in what the kernel costs. At 192 agents it runs in 0.164 ms at one retained peer and 0.185 ms at sixteen, a rise of thirteen per cent, against an eightfold rise for the argmax kernel over the same range; what remains of the growth is the aggregation, which is linear in k by construction, and not the selection.

It is also five times the cost of dense attention across that whole range, and it overtakes the argmax kernel only at sixteen retained peers, where both already cost more than five times dense. At 384 and 512 agents it is worse still, thirteen to sixteen times dense at every sparsity below thirty-two retained peers, because a row-wide sort needs the whole score row resident and the block of queries that can share a program shrinks as the row grows. Having both properties does not help. The sort that buys independence from k costs more than the argmax rounds it replaces throughout the range in which sparsity would otherwise pay.

The second obstacle is one dense attention avoids and none of our sparse kernels does. Dense attention streams keys and values in blocks under an online softmax, keeping a small tile resident whatever N is. Each of our sparse kernels instead holds the N-wide score row — in registers to rank it, or in place to sort it — so fewer queries can be in flight per streaming multiprocessor as N grows, and the tiling the search chooses for it is narrower at every size. What is fundamental to exact score-then-select is that all N scores must be *computed* before the retained set is known; that they must all be *resident* is not, and a streaming exact top-k that keeps a running candidate set would relax it. We report the constraint we measured and mark it as ours.

B.3 Sensitivity to head width and batch

Across head widths to 512, and at the agent counts from 192 upward that carry claims, the crossover exists only at the two narrowest: the best sparse implementation is faster than the best dense one at head widths 16 and 32 at every agent count, and at no agent count for head width 64 or above, where it is 1.3 to 2.3 times slower (Appendix E). The launch-bound 96-agent column has one exception, 0.88 at head width 64, which we do not read as a result. The ratio does not fall monotonically with head width; it reverses.

That is what the byte criterion predicts. Byte-neutrality requires $kd \leq N$, so widening the head at fixed agent count tightens the bound on the retained set proportionally, and at head width 128 the criterion

Table 7: Per-stage accounting for both paths at N=512. The last column is the fraction of whichever machine limit binds the stage, and it separates a stage that is badly implemented from one doing the only thing its access pattern permits. The byte counts are analytic and count each tensor once, so a figure above 100% marks a stage whose working set is partly served from cache. That happens for the softmax stages here and, at smaller agent counts, for the gather; it bounds the model's error at around +50 percentage points, which is larger than several of the gaps in the column and is why we do not read small differences off it. Peak measured on the same device: 57.8 TFLOP/s and 1497 GB/s, a ridge point of 39 FLOP/byte.

stage	GFLOP	GB	FLOP/byte	ms	TFLOP/s	GB/s	% of limit
score product	2.15	0.29	7.53	0.549	3.91	520	35
softmax over N	0.34	0.54	0.62	0.336	1.00	1598	107
dense aggregation	2.15	0.29	7.53	0.235	9.13	1213	81
top-k selection	0.00	0.47	—	3.271	—	143	10
softmax over k	0.08	0.13	0.62	0.059	1.42	2268	151
gather of V	0.00	1.21	—	0.954	—	1265	84
sparse aggregation	0.53	1.14	0.47	0.816	0.65	1398	93

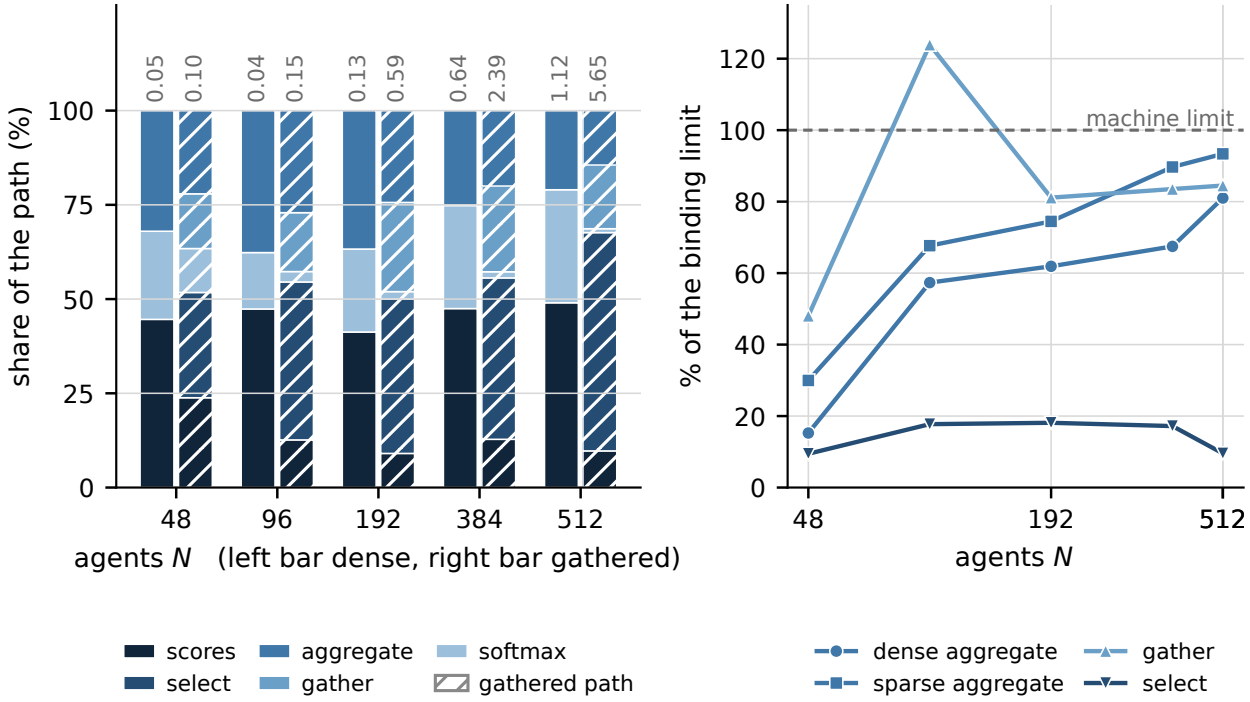


Figure 4: **Left:** how each path divides its time. Selection grows to dominate the gathered path as the agent count rises. **Right:** how close each stage runs to the machine limit that binds it.

permits only $k \leq 4$ at 512 agents — by which point the selection cost of Section 4.4 has already overtaken the saving. Widening the batch over a thirty-twofold range, by contrast, moves the ratio by up to a third — from 0.54 to 0.72 at 512 agents — and never across parity, which is the expected behaviour of a quantity that is a ratio of per-element costs.

B.4 Where the time goes

Low arithmetic intensity in a batched matrix–vector product is the natural explanation for the sparse contraction's slowness, and it is not the right one. Timed in isolation and charged with its own arithmetic and traffic, both aggregations sit near the bandwidth the device attains on a large copy — 93% for the sparse

Table 8: Forward, backward and their sum, for the differentiable implementations. The sparse path's backward is cheap relative to its forward, because selection has almost no adjoint, so the gap against fused dense narrows without closing. Restricted to the agent counts that reproduce: below 192 the forward and the forward-plus-backward passes are timed in separate interleaved blocks, and the contention between blocks exceeds the backward's own cost, which at two configurations produced a difference a backward pass cannot have.

		dense, unfused			dense, fused			top-k masked			top-k gathered			
N	k	f	b	f+b	f	b	f+b	f	b	f+b	f	b	f+b	gathered f+b ÷ fused f+b
192	32	0.136	0.166	0.302	0.072	0.219	0.291	0.454	0.460	0.914	0.424	0.201	0.625	2.1
384	64	1.082	1.604	2.686	0.220	0.728	0.948	3.065	3.365	6.430	2.405	1.593	3.998	4.2
512	128	1.899	2.648	4.547	0.349	1.203	1.552	6.985	5.748	12.734	6.435	3.142	9.577	6.2

contraction and 81% for the dense multiply it replaces (Table 7). The gap between them is smaller than the byte model's own error, so the model cannot order the two; what it does establish is that neither sits on a worse hardware path. The sparse one is slower because it moves about four times the bytes, since the compacted operand carries kd elements per query where the score row carries N. The corrected account is simpler, checkable before the code is written, and it is the $kd \leq N$ criterion of Section 4.2.

Selection is a different case, and it is the one stage where the raw decomposition is misleading in the opposite direction. It is the largest stage of the composed sparse path, and it runs at under a tenth of the bandwidth the device attains: it must read the score matrix and write values and indices, and moving those bytes and nothing else would take a small fraction of the time it does. That headroom is real, and the fused kernels realise part of it. What no kernel removes is that the score matrix must be formed and ranked at all, and the fused measurements of Section 4.4 show what remains once the headroom is taken.

B.5 Backward pass and training throughput

Every latency reported so far is a forward pass, which for a training claim is half the question. Timing forward and backward under the same protocol leaves the ordering intact and roughly a third of the margin (Table 8). The gathered path's backward costs about half its own forward, because the expensive stage — selection — has almost no adjoint: the retained indices are recorded in the forward pass and the backward is a scatter of gradients into them. Dense attention's backward costs several times its forward. At 512 agents the gathered path is 18.4 times the fused dense path on the forward alone and 6.2 times on forward and backward together, and the same narrowing appears at every agent count in the table. The sparse path's disadvantage in training is therefore substantially smaller than the forward-only measurements suggest, and remains a disadvantage. The fused kernels are excluded from this comparison: they are hand-written forward passes, and timing one against an autograd graph would compare two different things.

End to end, none of this is visible. Timing a complete training iteration by phase, with the communication implementation swapped and everything else fixed, puts the environment and per-step action selection at 78% of the iteration at six agents and 96% at twenty-four, and leaves all five implementations within 2% of one another at every agent count, against an iteration-to-iteration spread of 0.8 to 7.3% (Table 9). The ordering among the five is not stable: the communication-free variant, which performs no attention at all, is fourth of five at six agents and at twenty-four, and the gathered sparse implementation is the fastest of the five at twenty-four. This does not resolve the implementations as equal; it fails to resolve them at all, which is the useful description as well as the honest one. It bounds the practical stakes of the whole measurement campaign in the regime the training study occupies, and it is why the computational argument is made on the module in isolation.

B.6 Robustness

The ordering is unchanged under `torch.compile` and CUDA-graph capture, at `bf16`, and on an x86_64 CPU whose machine balance differs from the GPU's by more than an order of magnitude. The CPU comparison

Table 9: Where one MAPPO iteration spends its time. Differences between communication implementations are at or below the iteration-to-iteration spread in the rightmost column.

		share of the iteration (%)							
N	communication	environment	acting	update fwd	update bwd	optimiser	s/iter	÷ fused	spread
6	none	49	29	11	6	4	2.11	1.002	4.6
6	dense, unfused	48	30	12	6	4	2.09	0.992	7.3
6	dense, library fused	48	30	12	6	4	2.10	1.000	4.0
6	top-k, masked	48	30	12	6	4	2.09	0.996	5.4
6	top-k, gathered	49	29	12	6	4	2.13	1.011	5.3
12	none	76	14	5	2	2	4.35	0.998	2.3
12	dense, unfused	75	14	6	4	2	4.39	1.007	3.8
12	dense, library fused	75	14	6	3	2	4.36	1.000	3.3
12	top-k, masked	75	14	6	3	2	4.39	1.008	5.6
12	top-k, gathered	75	14	6	4	2	4.41	1.011	2.3
24	none	92	5	2	1	1	12.84	1.002	4.2
24	dense, unfused	91	5	2	1	1	12.98	1.013	3.3
24	dense, library fused	91	5	2	1	1	12.81	1.000	1.6
24	top-k, masked	91	5	2	1	1	12.80	0.999	0.8
24	top-k, gathered	91	5	2	1	1	12.76	0.996	1.7

required controlling an effect unrelated to attention: with the default allocator the multi-MiB temporaries each implementation frees between calls are returned to the kernel and re-faulted on the next call, which at N=192 adds roughly 37,000 minor page faults per forward and inflates latency by up to 8.8×. The tax is proportional to the bytes of large temporaries each implementation churns, so it does not cancel in a ratio, and in an un-pinned run it inverted the ordering at one configuration. With the heap pinned the inversion disappears. Appendix F.4 gives the procedure and both runs.

Because clocks are unlocked and the host is shared, we re-ran the identical sweep with the device otherwise idle and again under a concurrent load. With the device idle the ratios reproduce to within a few per cent; under load absolute latency moves by more than 100% while the paired ratios move by roughly half that, and every ratio moves against the sparse path. Pairing removes the typical drift rather than the tail, so the quantity that matters is the margin: no condition we measured brings a composed sparse implementation below parity, and the fused crossover reported in Section 4.4 is measured on the quietest device state we could obtain. Appendix E.3 gives the figures.

B.7 Selecting before scoring in detail

The paragraphs below describe the first pre-score sweep, which timed the all-pairs and Z-order selectors (Table 10, Figure 3); the second sweep of Section 4.6 adds the grid selector and FlexAttention and reproduces its Z-order and all-pairs rows.

Fused, the escape delivers, and how much depends on how many peers are kept. At two retained peers the attention stage costs 0.60, 0.44, 0.19, 0.08 and 0.06 times dense attention from 48 to 512 agents; at four, 0.79, 0.46, 0.24, 0.12 and 0.09. The best case over the grid is 0.060, sixteen times faster than dense, at 512 agents and two retained peers. The advantage narrows as k grows and is gone at the smallest agent count by sixteen retained peers, where the stage costs 1.06 times dense behind the Z-order selector and 1.39 behind the nearest-neighbour one, whose retained rows are scattered rather than adjacent. That shape is what the accounting predicts once the score term shrinks with the aggregation, and no score-then-select implementation in this paper comes close to it at any sparsity, because none of them can remove the score term.

Composed from library operators, the same stage is slower than dense attention at every one of the forty configurations, by 1.03 to 5.58 times. Fusing it is worth between 4.0 and 17.3 times, and the factor grows with the agent count because the gathered tensor the composition writes and re-reads grows with it. We

Table 10: Selecting before scoring, at 2 retained peers, every ratio against the better of the vendor library and our own dense kernel at the tiling the search of Section 4.4 found. Composing the attention stage from library operators costs an order of magnitude more than fusing it, and the difference decides the conclusion: composed, the attention is slower than dense attention at every configuration measured; fused, it is up to sixteen times faster.

		ops	**measured (ms)**			**best**	**÷ best dense**		
				attend			attend		total
N	selector	saved	select	composed	fused	dense	composed	fused	fused
48	nearest neighbours	10	0.049	0.030	0.005	0.008	3.96	0.60	6.91
48	Z-order window	18	0.102	0.031	0.005	0.008	3.99	0.60	13.79
96	nearest neighbours	12	0.100	0.045	0.006	0.014	3.22	0.44	7.58
96	Z-order window	36	0.113	0.045	0.006	0.014	3.23	0.44	8.44
192	nearest neighbours	14	0.324	0.075	0.007	0.034	2.20	0.20	9.51
192	Z-order window	71	0.121	0.077	0.007	0.034	2.24	0.19	3.71
384	nearest neighbours	15	1.757	0.137	0.010	0.108	1.27	0.09	16.42
384	Z-order window	140	0.124	0.138	0.009	0.108	1.28	0.08	1.23
512	nearest neighbours	15	5.449	0.177	0.010	0.172	1.03	0.06	32.41
512	Z-order window	184	0.129	0.177	0.010	0.172	1.03	0.06	0.83

report both columns because the composed one is what we measured before writing the kernel, and on its own it supports the opposite conclusion.

End to end the selector decides the outcome, and the two selectors behave oppositely. The Z-order selector's cost is nearly flat in the agent count — 0.102 to 0.142 ms across the range — so its share of the path falls as attention grows more expensive: at four retained peers the whole path costs 13.9, 8.7, 3.8, 1.28 and 0.85 times dense attention from 48 to 512 agents. The nearest-neighbour selector moves the other way. It materialises an $N \times N$ distance matrix and ranks it, which is Corollary 1(b), so beyond 96 agents its cost grows quadratically and its path rises to 32.3 times dense.

The end-to-end crossing at 512 agents needs a qualification the attention stage does not. It is a best-case result and it does not survive a change of estimator. Every latency in this paper is a minimum over interleaved samples, an estimate of what the configuration costs when the shared device is not being disturbed. Under that estimator the Z-order path costs 0.83 times dense at two retained peers and 0.94 at eight, and the two runs of the sweep agree to within 2.3%. Under the paired median of the same samples it costs 2.06 times dense instead. The reason is visible in the dispersion: the pre-score path is several library kernels behind one selector, and on a contended device the tail of a multi-launch path is much heavier than the tail of a single dense kernel, so the median charges it for contention that the minimum removes from both sides. We therefore report the crossing as an uncontended-envelope result and make no claim about end-to-end cost under load. The attention stage carries no such caveat: it is 16.8 times faster than dense on minima and 15.7 on medians.

Three things follow, and together they are the paper's constructive result.

Escaping the operation-count ceiling is necessary and not sufficient. Both selectors escape it, by between 7 and 108 times in operations at four retained peers, and one of them is an order of magnitude slower than dense attention while the other is faster. What separates them is whether the selector reaches its decision through a structure of the size it was introduced to avoid. Corollary 1 says as much before any measurement: the nearest-neighbour selector is capped at a constant by its own all-pairs structure. What the measurement adds is that the cap binds far below its analytic value, because the selector's cost is traffic rather than arithmetic and the count charges only the arithmetic.

A cheap selector is not sufficient either. With the attention stage composed from library operators the Z-order path is slower than dense at every agent count we measure, and only the fused kernel brings the total to parity at all. Both conditions are needed, and an operation count expresses neither.

And the regime matters, in a way that limits what this result recommends. The crossing appears at 512 agents, the largest count we measure, and we do not extrapolate past it. Most of the multi-agent communication systems we surveyed run with two to thirty agents, and the graph-structured ones reach the low hundreds (Section 2); at those counts our own measurements put the pre-score path behind dense attention, by 13.9 times at 48 agents and 1.28 at 384. So the negative result of Section 4 is the one that bears on current practice, and this section is a demonstration of a mechanism rather than a recommendation to adopt this implementation. What it supplies to a designer is a question with a checkable answer in place of an appeal to an operation count: whether the selector avoids a structure of the size it was introduced to remove, and whether the sparse attention it leaves behind is executed in a kernel written for it.

C Sources of measurement error

Each error described below produced a spurious result during this study before it was caught, and in each case the first symptom was a plausible number rather than an obvious error. The causes group into four kinds, and the grouping is useful because the kinds differ in how they are caught. Table 11 lists them with the corrective practice each forced.

Instrumentation. A diagnostic that synchronises the device inside the timed region measures the synchronisation. Our attention module computed an entropy statistic through a call that transfers a scalar to the host, and with it enabled dense latency was nearly flat in N while its work grew by two orders of magnitude — a result we briefly read as evidence that the quadratic cost does not manifest. Synchronising without naming the device is the complementary error: work submitted to a non-default device is never waited on, and every kernel at every size then reports the event-resolution floor of about 0.4 μs. On the host, the default allocator returns the multi-MiB score matrices each implementation frees between calls, so the next call re-faults them; at N=192 that added roughly 37,000 minor page faults per forward and inflated latency by up to 8.8×. Errors of this kind leave traces — an impossible latency, a curve that is flat where it should be quadratic, a non-monotone cost — and are caught by looking at the shape of the result rather than its value.

Interference from a shared device. Timing implementations in sequential blocks makes each block hostage to whatever else was running during it. On our shared host the recorded inter-run spread reaches 374% at one configuration of the released sweeps, and the sessions that produced our tiling searches differ from each other by up to 81% on identical shapes. Interleaving the implementations repetition by repetition lands any interference burst on all of them at once, so the ratios between them survive even when the absolute numbers drift. The residual sensitivity is to which implementations share an interleaved sweep: at small N, where a fixed per-call cost is a large share of the measurement, the launch count of the whole group enters every measurement in it, and two of our own sweeps that differ only in which implementations they time disagree by 1.4× at twelve agents. Sweeps that will be compared must therefore hold their implementation set fixed and say so.

Measuring a different algorithm from the one claimed. The two most dangerous errors are of this kind, because the resulting numbers are internally consistent, reproducible, and stable under every check the others would fail. They answer a different question from the one being asked. Applying top-k as a mask leaves the dense aggregation matmul in place, so the advertised saving is never executed; a FLOP model based on $1 - k/(N-1)$ nonetheless credits that code with a 75% saving at N=512, k=127, and with more than 90% wherever $k/(N-1) < 0.1$. Comparing against unfused dense alone is the same error in the baseline: at N=512 the unfused and fused dense paths differ by 5.4×, so which one is meant sometimes changes the answer. The defence is to state the operation count each implementation executes alongside its latency, and to check which backend actually serves each shape and dtype, both of which make a mismatch between the claimed and the executed algorithm visible immediately.

Table 11: Eight ways a benchmark measures something other than the algorithm, each of which produced a spurious result in this study. The first five are caught by the shape of the result; the last three are not, because the numbers they produce are self-consistent.

Kind	Cause	Symptom	Corrective practice
Instrumentation	Host transfer inside the timed region	Dense latency nearly flat in N	Gate diagnostics behind a flag that is off while timing
	Synchronisation without a device argument	Every kernel reports the event-resolution floor	Pin the device and pass it to every synchronisation
	Host allocator returning large temporaries	Up to 8.8× inflation and a non-monotone curve	Pin the heap; count minor faults per forward
Interference	Timing implementations in sequential blocks	Swings above 100% between identical configurations	Interleave repetition by repetition; report paired ratios
	Changing which implementations share a sweep	Two sweeps disagree by 1.4× at twelve agents	Fix the implementation set across comparable sweeps
Wrong algorithm	Benchmarking a masked implementation as sparse	The advertised saving is never executed	Assert executed FLOPs differ and trace the products issued
	Comparing only against unfused dense	A 5.4× more favourable comparison at N=512	Report both baselines; check which backend serves the shape
Wrong baseline	A hand-written sparse kernel against a vendor's dense kernel	An apparent speedup larger than the analytic ceiling permits	Write the dense baseline in the same framework and tiling

Attributing implementation quality to the algorithm. The fourth kind appeared only when we wrote our own kernels. Timing a hand-written sparse kernel against a vendor library's dense kernel measures sparsity and authorship at once. At the head widths used in multi-agent communication, PyTorch's fused attention path runs at roughly half the rate of a straightforward Triton kernel, because it is tuned for the long sequences and wide heads of language models. Against it our fused sparse kernel appears up to 2.8× faster, which is more than sparsity can supply at any k and was how we noticed. Matched authorship is the obvious remedy and it is not sufficient either: two kernels by the same author can differ by more than the margin under test. The condition that identifies the algorithm is matched *efficiency*, so we search one parameter space for both under one admissibility filter — which admits very unequal numbers of configurations, and we report those counts too — and give the fraction of the device's own arithmetic rate each kernel reaches (Section 4.4). That is also what reveals when neither implementation is near the machine, which is a different warning and one worth having: a comparison between two kernels at a third of peak resolves the algorithms only if the margin exceeds the headroom, and ours does not everywhere.

One belief of our own also needed correcting. We assumed that standard counters are blind to fused attention kernels, which would make a FLOPs-only comparison unable to see the baseline that matters. In PyTorch 2.11 that is not so: `torch.utils.flop_counter` reports the fused path correctly, and it was our harness that added an analytic term on top of the counter's output for that implementation, publishing a figure 1.83× too large. The narrower point generalises better than the one we started with: a counter has to be validated against the kernels it is expected to observe, because only a counter attached to the running program can contradict a FLOP model.

D Learning study

Sparsification would still be worth having if it cost nothing in return. Testing that requires care, because on a task where the channel is not needed "sparsification is free" and "the channel was never used" make identical predictions, so we gate the study on positive controls and register the analysis plan before the

Table 12: The two positive controls, which were inspected before registration and are excluded from the correction, and the primary pre-registered comparison. $A-B$ is the difference of means and d the standardised effect. Appendix G gives the remaining five comparisons.

	$A-B$	95% interval	d	p
Positive controls, descriptive				
communicating − non-communicating, reference task	+4.26	[+3.15, +5.23]	—	0.0079
communicating − non-communicating, partially observable	+11.59	[+7.13, +16.44]	—	0.0079
Primary pre-registered comparison				
attention-selected peers − uniformly random peers, same budget	+4.03	[−3.35, +11.42]	+0.60	0.357

outcomes are inspected. The study is secondary, and its role is narrow: to establish that the architecture being sparsified does something, so that the sparsification comparisons are not vacuous, and to report what a five-seed design can and cannot resolve. No claim elsewhere in this paper rests on it.

Twelve variants at up to twelve agents, five seeds each, two million environment steps. The variants include an α-entmax normalisation (Peters et al., 2019) and a communication budget enforced by a Lagrangian (Achiam et al., 2017; Stooke et al., 2020) on a per-agent Gumbel-softmax gate (Jang et al., 2017). Scaling in the number of agents is left to the training-free measurements of Section 4, because a training step in this pipeline is dominated by the environment (Section B.5) and cannot attribute a latency difference to the communication module. Two positive controls establish that the channel carries something: a reference task in which each agent observes only its partner's goal, fixed at two agents where selection is degenerate, and a partially observable variant of a standard cooperative task, introduced here, in which a peer's relative position is withheld beyond a fixed radius. In the second, the fraction of peers visible falls with the agent count while the absolute number visible rises, because the world does not grow; that confound is why no claim here compares returns across agent counts.

The plan fixes the endpoint, six comparisons and their direction, an exact two-sided permutation test, the effect sizes, a bootstrap interval flagged approximate at five seeds, and a Holm–Bonferroni correction. It also fixes the power expectation in advance: at five seeds a first rejection requires one variant's seeds to lie entirely above the other's, so any null in the family is under-powered and is not evidence of absence, and no equivalence claim is available because no equivalence margin was registered. Appendix G.1 gives the chronology, the arithmetic behind that power statement, and the single amendment.

Both positive controls separate completely, each attaining the floor of the permutation test for this design (Table 12), and measured attention entropy on the partially observable control is 0.35 nats against a ceiling of 1.61, so the learned weighting is peaked rather than uniform. Sparsification is therefore being applied to an architecture whose communication machinery improves return under the evaluated setup. It does not follow that the learned attention channel alone accounts for the difference: the communicating variants carry 7–19% more trainable parameters and the reference task supplies a discrete utterance channel of its own, so the channel-specific causal claim would need a parameter-matched sham variant, which we do not have and do not claim.

The comparison the design exists for holds the communication budget, the executed aggregation cost and every hyperparameter fixed, and varies only whether peers are chosen by attention score or uniformly at random. Its point estimate favours attention by roughly two thirds of a standard deviation and its interval includes zero. The design lacked the power to resolve an effect of that size, which the pre-registered calculation said in advance; nothing follows about whether attention selects informatively. The remaining five comparisons are in Appendix G as point estimates with intervals (Agarwal et al., 2021), and all six are Holm-adjusted nulls.

Two environment limits bound the study further. At twelve agents neither variant learns the task well — the dense variant scores below a uniform-random policy and the sparse variant only just above it — so no comparison at that agent count is interpretable; and the centralised critic sees the same masked observations

as the actors, with no privileged global state, which departs from standard practice for this learner and is a plausible contributor.

E Additional benchmark results

E.1 The full parameter grid

Table 13 gives the best-over-implementations sparse latency divided by the best-over-implementations dense latency, across head width and across batch, at each agent count and at the most favourable sparsity available. Head width is swept to 512 and batch from 32 to 1024. The largest batch we attempted, 4096 at 512 agents, could not be measured: the score matrix alone runs to several gigabytes and the device is shared, so that configuration is absent.

Table 13: Best sparse divided by best dense, over head width (upper block) and batch (lower block). Values below one indicate sparsity winning. The 96-agent column is included for completeness and carries no claim, for the reason given in Appendix E.3. Each column comes from the sweep that varies that axis, so a figure here can differ from the same nominal quantity in Section 4.4 by the few per cent that separates two sessions.

head width d	N=96	N=192	N=512
16	0.85	0.76	0.82
32	0.51	0.79	0.70
64	0.88	1.29	2.23
128	1.41	2.19	1.84
256	2.07	2.04	2.05
512	1.54	1.71	2.31

batch B	N=96	N=192	N=512
32	0.54	0.65	0.54
1024	0.57	0.75	0.72

E.2 Dispersion behind the headline numbers

The primary statistic is the minimum over interleaved samples, on the modelling assumption that contention can only add time. That statistic is trustworthy only if the underlying sample was not wildly dispersed, so the harness records the median, the interquartile range and the spread of per-run medians for every configuration, and the released artifacts carry all of them. Two properties of this host limit what any of it can mean. Both GPUs carried other tenants' allocations and near-continuous utilisation throughout the campaign — tens of gibibytes, varying between sessions, which we observed but did not record per run — and clocks could not be locked. We therefore report the spread of per-run medians beside every configuration. Whether a bootstrap interval for a ratio of minima is meaningful depends on the contention process, which is not stationary on this host, so we do not report one for the minimum.

E.3 Drift control

The headline sweep was repeated in full on the same device, hours later and under different load from other tenants. Table 14 gives how far each agent count moved between the two runs, in absolute latency and in the ratio against the best dense implementation, which is the quantity every claim is stated in.

Across 44 configurations at each agent count the median movement in latency is 0.1% at 96 agents, 0.2% at 192, 0.6% at 384 and 6.1% at 512, and in the ratio 0.3, 0.2, 0.5 and 7.2%; the worst single configuration moves 12.6%. Which implementation is faster changes between the runs at exactly one configuration, 96 agents with two retained peers, where the ratio is 1.002 in one run and 0.998 in the other — a tie either way.

Table 14: Movement between two runs of the identical sweep, hours apart under different load. Median movement is at or below one per cent everywhere except 512 agents, where it is six to seven per cent; no single configuration moves by more than 12.6%, and no ordering the paper reports changes between the runs.

		latency $\lvert\Delta\rvert$ (%)		**ratio** $\lvert\Delta\rvert$ (%)	
N	configurations	median	max	median	max
96	44	0.1	4.2	0.3	2.5
192	44	0.2	6.1	0.2	6.0
384	44	0.7	11.3	0.5	11.6
512	44	6.1	12.0	7.2	12.6

Two things follow for how the sweeps are read. The measurement reproduces well enough that every ordering in this paper survives repetition, which is the property the claims depend on. And the largest agent count is the least stable one, not the most, so a margin of a few per cent there — which is what the end-to-end crossing of Section 4.6 is — is at the edge of what this device can resolve, and we say so where we report it. We restrict the crossover of Section 4.4 to 192 agents and above for a different reason: fixed per-call cost. A one-program Triton kernel that writes a single float, timed the way every measurement here is timed, costs 1.8 µs at its minimum and 2.3 µs at its median (`scripts/launch_overhead.py`). At 96 agents the fastest dense configuration is 13.8 µs and the fastest fused sparse one 11.7 µs, so that fixed cost is an eighth of each, and the composed sparse path issues several kernels rather than one. At 512 agents the same cost is one per cent of the dense measurement. A ratio between implementations that issue different numbers of kernels is therefore partly a ratio of launch counts at the small agent counts, and stops being one by 192.

The pre-score sweep of Section 4.6 is repeated in the same way, and for a stronger reason: the crossing it reports is a margin of about ten per cent rather than a factor, and a margin of that size has to be shown to survive a second session before it can be reported at all. It does. The median movement in the ratio between the two runs is 0.7% and the worst is 8.5%; at the agent count that carries the crossing the median is 0.8% and the worst 3.6%, and the four cells the crossing itself is read off agree to within 1.5%. Unlike the core sweep, this one reproduces at every agent count it measures, which is why the section quotes it from 48 agents upward.

The repeat is on the same physical card, so it establishes stability across runs and hours, not independence from one device, and we were not able to obtain a second card free of other tenants. The tiling search of Table 2 was run twice, once on each card of the host. The two searches select the same configuration at 63 of the 72 shapes they share, and at head width 16, where most of what this paper reports lives, at 16 of the 18 shapes; the two disagreements are both sparse-kernel tilings. Their absolute times differ by as much as 81% with the contention each session carried. That is why the search contributes a configuration and not a latency: every sweep re-times that configuration in its own interleaved group, and the only place a latency from the search's own session appears is Table 2, whose columns are the search's own record and are labelled as such. All measurements reported here were taken on one of the two cards of this host, and no cross-device calibration is claimed.

F Implementation and measurement validation

F.1 Functional equivalence

Every implementation is checked against the reference at every configuration whose latency any released artifact reports: 158 combinations of agent count, head width and retained-peer count, 136 of them with $k < N - 1$ so that selection is actually exercised, over 1.25 million query rows in total. The check matters more than it looks. Exact top-k is discontinuous in the scores, so two implementations that accumulate the score product in different orders can rank a near-tied pair differently and aggregate over different peers, producing a large output difference from a rounding-level score difference. An earlier version of our per-query fused kernel computed the score row as a reduction instead of through the matrix-multiply units and

disagreed with the reference at a handful of configurations for exactly that reason; the kernels reported here use the same product as the reference.

With that fixed, every implementation agrees with the reference to `fp32` rounding — maximum deviation 3.2×10^{-6}, and zero for the two implementations that share the reference's operator sequence exactly — with one attributable exception, which is an ambiguity in the function rather than an error in an implementation. Exact top-k is only well defined when the k-th largest score is unique. The kernel that selects by threshold retains every peer at or above that score, so a tie there gives it k+1 peers; the kernel that sorts score–index pairs breaks the same tie by peer index, which is not the order a rank-based selection uses. Four query rows in 1.25 million have such a tie, at three of the 158 configurations, and those rows are the only place any implementation differs from the reference by more than rounding. Two further rows appear in the head-width sweep, at 192 agents and head width 128, where the same two kernels differ from the reference by 1.7 and 1.1 on one query row of 6144 at each of two retained-peer counts; the k-th score on those rows is tied to the bit, so the divergence is the ambiguity and not an error. The check is run by `scripts/verify_all_configurations.py` and by the sweep harness itself, both of which count how many query rows diverge as well as by how much, and admit a tie as the explanation only when no more rows diverge than have a tie.

The fused kernel for attention over a pre-chosen peer set is checked the same way against the composed path it replaces, at all 40 configurations of Section 4.6 and both selectors, over 315,392 query rows, to a maximum deviation of 1.1×10^{-6}. Its timed call also converts the retained indices to the integer width the kernel reads them at, which the composed path does not need, so the figure we report for it includes a cost the comparison does not require of it.

F.2 What each implementation executes

The masked and gathered implementations compute the same function while executing different work, which is the distinction the paper turns on, so regression tests pin it. Maximum absolute deviation between the two paths is below 10^{-10} in `float64`. A FLOP counter attached to the running program reports identical totals for dense and masked — the counter scores matrix products, and masked issues the same two as dense — against a smaller total for gathered, the difference being exactly the aggregation term. Tracing every matrix product confirms that the gathered path issues no dense aggregation product and does issue the compacted one, and that every top-k variant still issues the full score product, which is assumption A2 made mechanical.

The four hand-written kernels differ only in how the retained set is reached, and each one is stated here in the terms Section 4 compares them in. All four compute the score row through the same matrix-multiply sequence as the reference, in `ieee` precision: computing it as a reduction instead changes the summation order, and a rounding-level difference in a score is enough to change which peer is retained. The per-query kernel takes k argmax rounds over the score row and reads k value rows, so its aggregation is sparse and its selection is linear in k. The threshold kernel bisects on the score's integer bit pattern for 34 steps to find the k-th largest value exactly, then weights every peer by an indicator, so its selection is independent of k and its aggregation is dense. The sorted kernel maps each score to an order-preserving integer, packs it against its own peer index into one 64-bit word, sorts the row once, and reads the k value rows named by the top words, so it is independent of k and sparse at the same time. The pre-score kernel is given the retained indices and never forms a score row at all: one program per tile of queries walks that tile's retained peers, reading one key row and one value row per peer and accumulating with a running maximum, so nothing of size (B, N, k, d) is ever written.

F.3 Which backend serves the fused dense baseline

A probe forces each scaled-dot-product backend in turn, at both dtypes and at three agent counts, under no mask, an additive float mask and a Boolean mask, and the profiler records which kernel the default dispatcher launches. The FlashAttention backend is rejected under any non-null mask in either form, and in `fp32` under any input, so the library dense baseline runs the memory-efficient CUTLASS kernel. Forcing FlashAttention on the same unmasked `bf16` shape is faster than the kernel we do get, so a baseline able to

reach it would widen rather than narrow the gap we report — which is part of why the dense baseline in this revision is the better of the library path and a kernel we wrote.

F.4 The host allocator control

Dense, masked and gathered each allocate and free several multi-MiB score matrices per forward. The default allocator returns those pages to the kernel and they are re-faulted on the next call, which at N=192 adds roughly 37,000 minor page faults per forward and inflates latency by up to 8.8×. The tax is proportional to the bytes of large temporaries each implementation churns, so it differs per implementation and does not cancel in a ratio; in an un-pinned run it inverted the ordering at one configuration. We raise the allocator's retention threshold so that freed temporaries are kept, and count minor faults per forward from the process's own resource usage across the timed region. The harness records the allocator environment, the thread counts, the affinity mask and the fault totals in each run's metadata. The fault figures quoted here come from the host microbenchmark that first exposed the effect, which predates the re-measurement campaign; the campaign's own artifacts inherit the fix and do not re-derive the fault counts, so those two numbers should be read as the diagnosis that motivated the control rather than as a released measurement.

F.5 Machine balance

Peak arithmetic rate is measured with a large matrix multiply and peak bandwidth with a large copy, in the same process as the measurements they normalise. That matters here more than it usually would: on this shared host the peak we measure varies between 58 and 77 TFLOP/s across sessions, depending on what else is running. Every fraction-of-peak figure in the paper is against the peak measured in the same process as the number it normalises, and is therefore an upper bound on the true efficiency rather than an estimate of it. Comparisons between two implementations measured in one process are unaffected; comparisons of a fraction across sections are not, and we make none. The copy source is written before it is read: an untouched allocation on this operating system is backed by the shared zero page, so a host-side copy from it re-reads one cache line and reports a bandwidth several times the machine's real figure, and an earlier version of this probe did exactly that: every CPU ridge point derived from it was too large by roughly a factor of six. Device work is also timed with device events rather than host wall-clock, since host timing around a sub-millisecond copy measures launch and synchronisation. The probe reports two ridge points per device, one with a cache-resident buffer and one with a buffer larger than the last-level cache, because the two differ by a factor of two on the host and a claim that holds for one need not hold for the other.

G Additional training analysis

G.1 Pre-registration chronology

The analysis plan was committed when eight of the forty runs in the pre-registered family had produced a final evaluation and before any of their returns had been inspected. The timestamped history in the anonymised supplementary archive establishes the ordering: the positive-control artifacts at 12:18, the plan at 12:56, and the remaining artifacts at 19:11 the same day. The plan has two commits, the second appending to its deviations log; the endpoint, comparisons, test, effect sizes, interval and correction are byte-identical to the pre-unblinding version. Timestamps establish ordering and nothing more. Data generation had demonstrably already begun.

The power statement in Section D is arithmetic, not an estimate. With five seeds per variant an exact two-sided permutation test over $\binom{10}{5} = 252$ assignments has smallest attainable p-value $2/252 = 0.0079$, against a first Holm threshold of $0.05/6 = 0.0083$: a margin of 3.97×10^{-4}. A first rejection therefore requires one variant's five seeds to lie entirely above the other's, and any effect smaller than complete separation is undetectable by construction.

One correction is logged against the released plan. It asserts that at most one comparison in the family can reach corrected significance. That is false: Holm is a step-down procedure, so once a first rejection is

obtained its later thresholds are looser and further rejections remain possible. The manuscript states the corrected version; the deviation is logged against the released plan.

G.2 The remaining comparisons

Five further comparisons were registered and all are Holm-adjusted nulls. Two deserve a note. The comparison at twelve agents has the one sign opposite to its registered direction and carries the family's largest point estimate, and we set it aside on the ground that neither variant learns the task there. That ground was not registered: it is a post-hoc exclusion of the largest observed effect, we have logged it as a deviation against the released plan, and a reader who rejects it should read the comparison as an under-powered null with a large point estimate, which is what the registered analysis returns either way. The evidence for the exclusion is this. A uniform-random policy scores -758.9 under a forty-episode evaluation, against -864.9 for the dense variant, which is worse, and -717.9 for the sparse variant, which is better but barely learning; the comparison is between a diverged run and a struggling one. Separately, for two comparisons the bootstrap interval excludes zero while the permutation test does not. The registration named the permutation test, so it governs; the disagreement is unsurprising at five seeds, where the interval is coarse, discrete and of uncertain coverage. We report both so that the estimated effect and the strength of evidence for it are both visible.

Descriptively, and supporting no claim: the budgeted variant meets its budget but not by the intended route, its gate collapsing to an expected support near one within the first tenth of training while the dual multiplier decays to zero; the entmax variant settles at a support of 1.64 of five peers; and attention entropy falls from 0.35 nats over five peers to 0.12 over two. The three sit on different supports and are reported only as an instrumentation check.

G.3 The partially observable environment

The variant modifies the standard cooperative task in one respect: a peer's relative-position entry is zeroed when the peer is farther than a fixed radius. Reward, action space, landmark observations, episode length and observation dimension are unchanged. Two properties limit what it can support. The mask is a zeroing rather than an explicit visibility flag, so a peer at relative position exactly zero is not distinguishable from an absent one. On a continuous position space that coincidence has probability zero and we did not observe it, but we did not instrument for it either, and the released characterisation records visible fractions only. And the visible fraction falls with the number of agents while the absolute number visible rises, because the world size is fixed, which is a difficulty confound that rules out across-agent-count return comparisons.

The communicating variants carry between 7.2% and 19.0% more trainable parameters than the communication-free baseline, since the attention module adds parameters the baseline has no analogue for. The positive controls therefore establish that the communicating architecture outperforms the baseline, not that the channel alone accounts for the difference.

H Literature audit

For each audited paper we read the full text, including appendices and the official supplement where one exists — through the ar5iv rendering of the arXiv version where the paper is on arXiv, and the venue's own copy otherwise — searched it for seven temporal keywords, and recorded whether it makes a computational-efficiency or complexity claim about its mechanism, whether it reports any measured temporal quantity attributable to that mechanism, and the figure, table or sentence that settled the decision. A statement such as "training took a few days" does not qualify, since it is not attributable to the mechanism. Scope matters for at least one entry, whose affirmative verdict rests on a wall-clock figure in an appendix and would be negative on the main body alone. This is an audit of reporting practice in a small, deliberately selected set — the papers we ourselves relied on — and not a sample of either literature; a negative verdict means the argument rests on operation counts or asymptotics, not that it is wrong.

Table 15: The twelve audited papers, their efficiency claim, the kind of evidence it rests on, and whether any measured temporal quantity attributable to the mechanism appears anywhere in the paper or its supplement. A "no" means the argument rests on operation counts or asymptotics, not that it is wrong.

Paper	Efficiency claim	Type	Measured time?
Multi-agent communication and attention			
Das et al. (2019)	Qualitative bandwidth argument only	qualitative	no
Jiang & Lu (2018)	Communication is 'restricted by bandwidth . . .	agent/message counts	no
Jiang et al. (2020)	receiving a large amount of information . . .	asymptotic / qualitative	no
Singh et al. (2019)	continuous communication allows efficient . . .	message counts / convergence epochs	no
Sukhbaatar et al. (2016)	none explicit	—	n/a
Wen et al. (2022)	Sequence modelling 'reduces the complexity . . .	asymptotic	**yes**
Efficient attention and sparse mixture-of-experts			
Beltagy et al. (2020)	Sliding-window + global attention scales . . .	asymptotic	**yes**
Choromanski et al. (2021)	FAVOR+ gives linear rather than quadratic . . .	asymptotic	**yes**
Fedus et al. (2022)	Sparse routing increases parameters at . . .	FLOPs-matched	**yes**
Kitaev et al. (2020)	LSH attention reduces O(L2) to O(L log L)	asymptotic	**yes**
Shazeer et al. (2017)	1000x capacity increase at minor . . .	FLOPs + measured	**yes**
Zaheer et al. (2020)	reduces this quadratic dependency to linear'; . . .	asymptotic + memory	no

I Reproduction and provenance

The measurement campaign is training-free and completes in about three hours on one device, most of it the per-format tiling searches of the precision study. `scripts/run_revision_campaign.sh` regenerates the fourteen artifacts every table and figure in this paper is built from, in the order the manuscript reports them; the equivalence sweep (`scripts/verify_all_configurations.py`), the launch-cost probe (`scripts/launch_overhead.py`) and the backend probe of Appendix F are separate entry points and are named where they are used. Results not produced by the current campaign — the host-side allocator diagnosis and the numerical-format robustness checks — date from an earlier campaign on the same host, and we say so where they are quoted; `scripts/make_revision_tables.py` and `scripts/make_revision_figures.py` regenerate every table and figure from those artifacts, so no tabular number in the manuscript is transcribed by hand; and `scripts/check_revision_numbers.py` re-derives the numbers that appear in prose and fails on any disagreement. The campaign runs the tiling search first, because every sweep after it re-times the dense configuration the search selects; that is what makes each ratio in this paper a ratio against the best dense implementation we have rather than against whichever one a given sweep happened to build.

The environment is one NVIDIA RTX PRO 6000 Blackwell Server Edition (`sm_120`, 95 GiB, driver 610.43.02) of the two on a host with two Intel Xeon 6507P processors, under PyTorch 2.11 with CUDA 12.8 and Triton 3.6. Every latency outside the precision study of Section 4.5 is `fp32`, timed with CUDA events around a single call, interleaved implementation by implementation and repetition by repetition, with 20 warm-up repetitions discarded, 40 to 60 timed repetitions per block, and the whole block repeated three times; the reported figure is the minimum over all samples and the spread of the three per-run medians is recorded beside it. The tiling search enumerates query tiles of 16 to 128, key tiles or head chunks of 16 to 128,

two to eight warps and one to three pipeline stages, and admits a configuration when its key, value and accumulator blocks fit a 100 kB shared-memory budget; the precision study repeats that search separately in each format. FlexAttention is called through `torch.compile` with the recompilation limit raised and fallback to the unfused path disabled, since past the default limit it silently executes an implementation that materialises the score matrix.

Three provenance caveats. The hardware description and the aggregate provenance record were written before this project's environment was upgraded and describe a superseded software stack and a host that is no longer available; both have been corrected, and the run-level provenance for the training variants lives in the per-run configuration files rather than in the aggregate record. The GPUs used for every measurement in this paper are shared with other tenants, so absolute latencies are not reproducible to better than the drift reported in Appendix E.3 and only ratios between implementations timed in the same interleaved sweep should be compared. And the activation-memory measurement is reported from a run with the card otherwise free, since a shared-host repeat exhausts memory one agent count earlier.